

CM Rekha attends Odisha Parv-2026 celebration

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday attended the 'Odisha Parv-2026' celebration at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium along with Union Minister for Women and Child Development Annapurna Devi. Addressing the gathering, the Chief Minister extended warm greetings to the Odia community living in Delhi and praised the event as a vibrant celebration of Odisha's rich culture, traditions, and spiritual heritage.

She said it was a matter of pride and happiness that the culture, art, music,

dance, and traditions of Odisha were being showcased in such a grand manner in the national capital. According to her, Odia families living in Delhi remain deeply connected to their roots, cultural heritage, and their homeland.

Congratulating the organisers, she noted that Odisha Parv, which has been held every year since 2017, has now completed nearly a decade of its journey.

She said the Odia community in Delhi eagerly waits for this festival throughout the year because it is not just a cultural celebration but also a meaningful way for people to stay connected with their traditions and identity.

The Chief Minister said she felt fortunate to have the opportunity to address the Odia community in Delhi from the stage and described them as part of her extended family. Cultural events like these, she said, strengthen India's spirit of unity in diversity.

Sharing a personal experience, the chief minister said that when she assumed office as the Chief Minister of Delhi, she first travelled to Odisha to seek blessings of Lord Jagannath.

She also participated with devotion in the Jagannath Rath Yatra organised in Delhi and took part in the sacred ritual of "Chhera Pahara," following the traditional



customs associated with the yatra.

She said nearly 1.5 million people in Delhi are connected to Odisha, reflecting the true character of the capital where people from every state and culture live together. Delhi, she said, welcomes everyone with an open heart and gives every resident the confidence that the city belongs to them.

The chief minister also reassured people in Odisha that their family members living in Delhi are safe and that the Delhi government is attentive to their needs and concerns.

The Chief Minister added that the Delhi government had, for the first time, cele-

brated Utkal Divas at the official level in a grand manner to honour the community.

She further said that Lord Jagannath is not only a centre of faith for the people of Odisha but is also worshipped with deep devotion by people from different communities in Delhi.

Rath Yatras dedicated to the deity are organised in the capital as well, and she acknowledged the efforts of those who continue to carry forward this tradition.

She praised Odisha's rich cultural legacy, including its art, literature, music, folk dances, and history, saying the state strengthens India's cultural unity through its diverse traditions.

Anti-encroachment drive carried out in Uttam Nagar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An anti-encroachment drive was carried out in Delhi's Uttam Nagar, with civic officials sealing several eateries in the area on Saturday.

Teams of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, assisted by the Delhi Police, launched the action amid tight security arrangements, deploying bulldozers to remove alleged illegal structures and seal shops operating in violation of civic norms.

The drive targeted a row of eatery outlets built outside the Uttam Nagar police station premises.

The action comes days after a 26-year-old man named Tarun was killed in a clash that broke out between his family and neighbours in



the JJ Colony. According to police, the violence started after water from a balloon thrown by a girl from Tarun's family splashed on a woman from the neighbour's family during Holi celebrations.

The incident had triggered tensions and demands for strict action against illegal establishments.

According to officials present at the site, the operation involved bulldozers and multiple teams from the municipal corporation to demolish unauthorised portions of the structures and seal the shops found operating illegally. Delhi Police personnel were also deployed to maintain law and order

during the exercise. Authorities said adequate security arrangements were made to prevent any untoward incident during the drive as a large number of locals gathered near the spot to witness the action.

A senior official said the action was part of an ongoing crackdown against illegal encroachments and unauthorised commercial activities in the area.

The police said they were present only to ensure security and smooth conduct of the operation.

Further action may be taken against other establishments in the area if violations are found during inspection.

A senior MCD official said that the anti-encroachment drive is a part of an ongoing drive in the west zone.

Forest department plans four-year eco-restoration exercise to remove invasive *kikar* from Ridge

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Forest Department is planning a four-year eco-restoration exercise to remove '*kikar*' and other invasive species from the Ridge forests of the national Capital, officials said on Saturday.

According to the officials, the project is taken up under a working plan approved by the Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change. The exercise forms part of the working plan for the forests of the National Capital Territory of Delhi for the period 2026-27 to 2036-37.

The project was discussed during a meeting of the Delhi Tree Authority last month.



The plan identifies invasive species such as Prosopis juliflora (*kikar*), Leucaena leucocephala and eucalyptus as threats to native biodiversity in ridge forest areas.

"The plan requires final clearance from the Supreme Court as the Ridge is under

judicial protection. Any major intervention in the forest area requires prior approval from the court," a senior official said.

According to the document, eco-restoration and enrichment plantation are planned across about

6,303.55 hectares over four financial years.

In 2026-27, eco-restoration is planned across 1,490 hectares with the plantation of about 28.56 lakh saplings. This includes 14,27,160 tree saplings and 14,29,200 shrubs, climbers and bamboo saplings.

In 2027-28, around 1,670 hectares will be covered with a plantation of about 25.85 lakh saplings, including 7,05,650 tree saplings and 18,79,900 shrubs, climbers and bamboo saplings.

In 2028-29, the department plans to cover 1,450.55 hectares with about 24.43 lakh saplings, comprising 7,09,220 tree saplings and 17,34,620 shrubs, climbers and bamboo saplings.

Khel Mahakumbh aims to strengthen sports ecosystem: Sood

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood on Saturday said the Delhi Khel Mahakumbh aims to strengthen the sports ecosystem in the capital and provide young athletes with opportunities to compete and prepare for higher-level competitions.

Speaking at the finals of the volleyball competition held at SKV A Block School in Janakpuri, Sood said the initiative is aimed at encourag-

ing participation of the youth in sports and helping athletes prepare for national and international events.

Additional Director Nitin Jindal was also present on the occasion. According to a statement, more than 23,000 players have participated in different sports during the past month of the competition.

Several final and semifinal matches across sports such as volleyball, football, basketball and wrestling were held on Saturday as the multi-sport event moves towards



its concluding stages.

Sood said that Delhi Khel Mahakumbh is not just a competition but an important initiative to strengthen

the future of players in Delhi. He stated that the Delhi Government is committed to creating a strong sports ecosystem for players so

that the youth of Delhi can perform better on national and international platforms.

In the men's open category volleyball final, LPN Club defeated Masters Academy to claim the title. In the women's open category final, Jaunti Club defeated Tikri Kalan to win the title.

In football, the semifinal of the girls' school category was played at Kohat Enclave Sports Complex between JDMC and Modern School, Vasant Vihar. The JDMC team won the match 3-0 to enter the final, it added.

Police arrest man wanted in multiple robbery, firing cases

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police arrested a 22-year-old alleged criminal wanted in multiple robbery and firing cases and recovered an illegal semi-automatic pistol from his possession.

Dhruv alias Raj alias Toofan, a resident of Jahangir Puri, was held from the Bhalswa Dairy area in north Delhi. Police said he was wanted in four cases of



robbery and firing registered at different police stations.

The arrest was made following a tip-off received on March 13 that Dhruv, who allegedly carries an illegal firearm and is active in crim-

inal activities, would come near Bhalswa Dairy Jheel on Golf Course Road to meet his associates. The team laid a trap and apprehended him. During a search, police recovered a loaded semi-automatic pistol along with two cartridges of 7.65 mm calibre from his possession.

The weapon and ammunition were seized, and a case under relevant sections of the Arms Act was registered against him.

The Pioneer Classified

◆ CHANGE OF NAME ◆

I, Parbhawati Devi, Mother of- No.14683126K Nk Mukesh Kumar Singh, R/o- Vill- Sahasawon, PO- & PS- Asaon, Dist- Siwan, Teh- Siwan, Bihar- 841287, have changed my name from Parbhawati Devi to Prabhavati Devi, vide affidavit dated 14/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(486)C I, Sharda, Mother of No.14849821W Nk Shrinath Khobreakar R/o- Vill- Mahaladarwada, PO- Sadashivgad, Teh- Karwar, Dist- Uttara Kannada, Karnataka- 581352, have changed my name from Sharda to Sharada Suresh Khobreakar, vide affidavit dated 14/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(487)C I, Suresh, Father of No.14849821W Nk Shrinath Khobreakar R/o- Vill- Mahaladarwada, PO- Sadashivgad, Teh- Karwar, Dist- Uttara Kannada, Karnataka- 581352, have changed my name from Suresh to Suresh Lolu Khobreakar, vide affidavit dated 14/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(488)C I, No.15688138Y Hav Lakshman Paswan, R/o- Vill- Pasi Tola, PO- Rampur Karkhana, Teh&Dist- Deoria, U.P.- 274405, have changed name& D.O.B of my son from Amish Paswan(23.06.2007) to Amish Kumar Paswan(23.06.2006) vide affidavit dated 05/03/2026 before Notary Public Barabanki, U.P

PD(489)C

I, No.15688138Y Hav Lakshman Paswan, R/o- Vill- Pasi Tola, PO- Rampur Karkhana, Teh&Dist- Deoria, U.P.- 274405, have changed name of my minor son BABY TWO OF SUSHMA ALIAS MUKUL aged 10 years and he shall hereafter be known as MUKUL.

PD(491)C I, SACHIN PUROHIT S/O DAYA SHANKAR PUROHIT R/O RZ B-153, RAJ NAGAR-1, PALAM COLONY, SOUTH WEST DELHI, DELHI-110039 have changed the name of my minor son BABY TWO OF SUSHMA ALIAS MUKUL aged 10 years and he shall hereafter be known as MUKUL.

PD(492)C I, Kamaljeet Kaur W/o Inderjit Singh R/o A-8, Titarpur, Najafgarh Road, Delhi-110027 have changed my name to Kamal. Kamaljeet Kaur & Kamal both names are one and same person.

PD(493)C

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Shri Vipin Pal who is purchasing the RESIDENTIAL FLAT NO. G-2, L.L.G TYPE, (GROUND FLOOR) WITHOUT ROOF RIGHTS, AREA MEASURING 37.16 SQ. METERS, BUILT ON PLOT NO. B-31, SITUATED IN THE AREA OF VILLAGE BRAHMAPUR ALIAS BHOUPURA, D.L.F., DILSHAD EXT-2, PARGANA LONI TEHSIL AND DIST. GHAZIABAD U.P. From Shri Sachin who had owned the subject property through GPA&TS and Will dated 05.10.2011 duly attested with the Notary Public Delhi dated 05/10/2011 which was executed by Nitin Dang. That, the Original Sale Deed dated 11/07/2006 executed by Shri Pradeep Kumar in favour of Shri Sumit Magadly registered in the office of SR&Ghaziabad as registration No. 7999, Addl. Book No. 1, Page Nos. 557-580, Volume No. 3761, Dated 11/06/2006 has been lost/misplaced/not available. Now, Shri Vipin Pal and Smt. Poonam Pal intend to purchase and mortgage the same against the financial assistance from Vastu Housing Finance Corporation Ltd. To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any person(s) having any objection regarding ownership and/or creating mortgage of the said property is/are hereby requested to intimate in writing to the undersigned about his objections within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucern Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the public that my client, Mrs. Rekha Hikari W/o Sh. Pankaj Hikari, Rio H. No. 865, F Type Quarter, Timarpur, Delhi is intending to purchase a property ie. vacant plot measuring 74.25 sq. yards (17.7' X 38') part of Khursa No.48/18 known situated at Village Salempur Majra Burari. Abadi known as Gali No. 37-F B Block, Kaushik Enclave Burari, Delhi-110084 from Sh. Rohit So Sh. Shyam Lal and bounded on:

East by: Other's Property, West by: Other's Property North by: Road 17 ft wide, South by: Other's Property

Any entity/person(s) having any claim, interest, or objection to this sale should contact the undersigned in writing within 10 days from this publication, with documentary evidence if no objection is received, the sale will proceed.

Neeraj Mandal (Advocate)
Ch. No. 540A, 3rd Floor, TS Hazari Court, Delhi-54

PUBLIC NOTICE
I, Birendra Bahadur Singh S/O D. R. Singh, R/o 3019 C 16th Avenue, Gaur City 2, GREATER NOIDA WEST, UP 201318 (Mob. No. 9818254595) has lost the Patta and other relevant documents of Plot No. 153, Khushi Nagar, Near Bansal College, Rohini Nagar-II, Mohabbatpura, Tehsil Phagi, Jaipur from his car. If any body finds the same then please return at the above said address.

PUBLIC NOTICE
Registered owners of following vehicles lying at the workshop of Courtesy Honda 3A Block B Wazirpur Industrial Area New Delhi-52 are hereby requested to collect their vehicles after clearing all outstanding dues within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. Failing which, the said vehicles shall be disposed of as deemed fit for recovery of dues, and no claim whatsoever shall be entertained thereafter.

Reg. No.	Model
DL1ZA8777	AMAZE
DL4CAV4388	ACCORD

Contact Person:
Mr. Abhay Sharma GM Service
Mobile no. 7290076268
serviceheadvzrallyautomobiles.net

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given on behalf of Smt. Manju who is owned of Property ID no. 372CK8C5, area measuring 5 Marla comprised in Khewat/Khata no.1485/Khata no.1652 Kharsa no.478/3/24(28-19), situated at Village Sohna, Tehsil Sohna, District-Gurgaon, Haryana, having acquired the same vide Transfer Deed dated 03/10/2025 executed by Shri Yogesh in favour of Smt. Manju duly registered in the office of SR&Ghaziabad as registration No. 3051, Addl. Book No. 1, Page Nos. 973-74 Volume No. 2059182, Dated 03/08/2011 has been lost/misplaced/not available. To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any person(s) having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucern Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

NDMC expands its automatic misting system to major roads



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) is strengthening the Delhi Government's ongoing efforts to curb pollution by expanding its automatic misting systems to 24 major roads under its jurisdiction.

The project is being implemented, with mist sprayers already installed on Lodhi Road, Shanti Path and Africa Avenue to mitigate road dust and airborne pollutants. In total, 17 mist spray systems have been installed on these stretches so far, according to officials.

This phase, according to the officials, is covering nearly 29 kilometres and around 1,323 electric poles. The officials added that the system releases fine water droplets from nozzles mounted on electric poles, helping dust particles settle and improving air quality in busy road corridors.

As part of the next phase, the NDMC has approved installation, testing and commissioning of automatic misting systems on 10

additional roads where dust and air pollution levels are relatively higher.

The council has cleared the proposal to award the work at a cost of ₹4.94 crore, which also includes one year of operation and maintenance.

The roads identified for this phase include Barakhamba Road, Firoz Shah Road, Sikandra Road, Bhagwan Dass Road, Copernicus Marg, Tilak Marg, Shanker Road, Mandir Marg, Dr Zakir Hussain Marg and Subramanian Bharti Marg.

NDMC vice-chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal said the initiative is aimed at suppressing dust and reducing pollution in high-traffic areas of the council zone. "The expansion is part of NDMC's continuing efforts to reduce road dust and improve environmental conditions in the central Delhi area," Chahal said.

The sprayers, mounted on electric poles, release fine water droplets into the air, helping dust and pollutants settle while also watering roadside plants using treated water.

Bike taxi driver arrested for molesting woman passenger

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 34-year-old bike taxi driver has been arrested for allegedly molesting a woman passenger during a ride in northwest Delhi's Rohini.

The incident occurred on March 12 when the woman booked a bike taxi through a mobile application to travel from Rohini Sector 15 to Pitampura.

In a complaint lodged at KNK Marg police station, the woman was travelling as a pillion rider when the accused allegedly started misbehaving with her near the Sector 13 dividing road on

KNK Marg. When she objected to his behaviour, the rider allegedly threatened her not to raise an alarm. The woman was later dropped near FU Block in Pitampura, following which she approached the police with a written complaint, officials said.

Based on the complaint, a case was registered on March 14 under sections 74 (Assault or criminal force to woman with intent to outrage her modesty), 79 (Word, gesture or act intended to insult the modesty of a woman) and 351(3) (Criminal intimidation) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, and an investigation

was taken up, a senior police officer said.

The accused, identified as Sachin, a resident of Badli village in Delhi, was subsequently arrested. The motorcycle used during the ride has also been seized by the police.

According to the police, the accused is a Class 10 pass and has been working as an app-based bike taxi driver for the past one year. During verification, it was also found that he had earlier been involved in a dowry death case registered at Samaypur Badli police station in 2011.

He was produced before a court which remanded him



to 14 days of judicial custody, police said.

According to the complainant, the bike rider began to behave indecently and harass her as soon as the ride

began. "He repeatedly touched me inappropriately... When I asked him not to do so, he started riding at a very high speed and repeatedly braked hard and sud-

denly, as a result of which I was very frightened," the woman stated in her complaint. The woman said that the rider initially began speeding within seconds of starting the trip and dismissed her concerns when she asked him to slow down.

"He arrogantly told me that he was only driving at 20 km/h and that I could check it myself. But after that he increased the speed further," she said.

She alleged that the rider repeatedly applied sudden brakes so that she would bump into him and deliberately drove over potholes at high speed, causing strong

jerks. "I asked him several times to ride properly, but he told me to sit quietly and said he knew how to drive," she said.

"After some time he suddenly started touching me. When I objected and asked what he was doing, he threatened me and said, 'Sit quietly or I will kill you,'" the woman claimed.

She also alleged that the rider deviated from the route shown on the map and threatened her again when she questioned him about it.

"I told him that if he did not stop the bike immediately, I would jump off. Despite that, he kept speeding and

abusing me. Finally, when I raised my voice loudly, he stopped," she said.

Even after stopping the bike, the rider continued threatening her, she added.

The police said further investigation in the case is underway.

Bike taxi services offered on platforms such as Uber and Rapido are popular with those who want to travel relatively small distances within the city at a cost that is lower than that of a regular app-based taxi. Bikes are a convenient option due to their ability to travel fast through heavy traffic and in narrow or congested roads.

Eateries scale back menus, bookings amid LPG crisis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Large corporate gatherings and group parties are now taking a backseat in restaurant calendars across the Capital, as eateries scale back menus and bookings amid an LPG supply crunch, with concerns over shrinking cooking gas stocks growing after military escalations in West Asia.

Restaurant owners, particularly in Connaught Place, one of the city's busiest dining hubs, said that preparing food for large tables requires significant gas usage, prompting many establishments to temporarily halt big party bookings while focusing on regular diners. Paramjeet Kaur, owner of Flavours of China, said the restaurant has scaled back certain offerings and limited group bookings in order to manage LPG consumption.

"We have had to make a few adjustments to manage the situation. For instance, we are currently not offering sizzlers, as they require continuous and high-flame



usage. We have also trimmed our menu and are focusing only on basic dishes that can be prepared with limited gas consumption," she said.

Kaur added that the restaurant has also temporarily stopped hosting large gatherings to conserve fuel. A manager at Amaltas, a restaurant in Greater Kailash, said the establishment has also been cautious about accepting large bookings

in the current situation.

"With the uncertainty around LPG availability, we are being careful about taking big table reservations or corporate events. Preparing food for large groups requires continuous gas usage, so we are prioritising regular diners and smaller tables for now," the manager said.

Inder, owner of Minar restaurant in Connaught Place, said his establishment has also decided to

avoid large-scale bookings until the LPG supply situation stabilises.

"At the moment, we are not taking corporate meetings or big events because managing such gatherings requires extensive cooking, and that means higher LPG consumption. Given the uncertainty around supply, it becomes difficult to plan for large bookings," he said.

The restaurant is offering 'tandoori roti', baked food and basics, as the idea is to

manage with the available resources and keep operations running smoothly, he said, adding that the hospitality industry is often among the first to feel the impact of disruptions.

Ankur, owner of 38 Barrack, said his restaurant is attempting to reduce dependency on LPG by using alternative cooking methods while also streamlining the menu.

"We are trying to manage the situation by using induction cooktops, electrical frying equipment and baking wherever possible. For certain dishes, we are also relying on charcoal-based tandoors, which helps reduce the pressure on LPG usage," he said.

While the restaurant is still hosting gatherings, Ankur said adjustments have been made in the kitchen.

Concerns over LPG availability have grown in several parts of the country in recent days after tensions and military escalations in West Asia raised fears of disruptions in global energy supply chains.

Police intensify surveillance across LPG godowns, distribution points

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Amid prevailing concerns over irregular LPG supply, the Delhi Police has intensified surveillance at LPG godowns and distribution points across the city. Officers have been deployed in plain clothes and are holding meetings with gas distributors, warning of strict legal action against anyone involved in black marketing.

This action comes a day after the cancellation of routine leave for police personnel to maintain law and order amid rising anxiety among households and businesses regarding the availability of cooking gas.

Police teams are now stationed near LPG godowns and distribution centres, both in uniform and in civilian attire, to monitor the situation closely and prevent hoarding and illegal sales of cylinders.

Senior officers have held discussions with gas distributors in their districts to ensure smooth distribution of



LPG cylinders to consumers. They have cautioned that strict action will be taken if any instances of black marketing are discovered.

"If anyone is found involved in black marketing or illegal sale of LPG cylinders, strict legal action will be taken, and a case will be registered under the relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS)," an officer said. According to the police, this increased vigilance aims to prevent panic buying, overcrowding, and any attempts to exploit the supply situation by selling cylinders at inflated prices.

On March 12, the Delhi Police

issued an order cancelling routine leave for its personnel to ensure adequate deployment across the city. The order, issued by the Joint Commissioner of Police (Operations), directed all districts and units not to grant routine leave until further instructions, except in genuine emergency cases after due verification and approval by the competent authority.

The communication had also asked district police units to keep a close watch on LPG distribution points and maintain law and order around gas agencies where long queues were being reported.

Govt preparing water master plan: Verma

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Considering the city's growing demand for drinking water and the need that will arise in the future, Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma said on Saturday that the Delhi Government is preparing a comprehensive water master plan, with a provision to rope in private players, to relieve the city residents of their woes.

Under the plan, a study of the existing infrastructure and the future expansion will be undertaken, keeping in mind the city's increasing population.

"There is a need for a holistic approach towards fixing the water sector challenges that we face, so for the first time a Water Master Plan will be presented. For this we have hired a consultant company which is studying all the major aspects, including sources of water, requirements in the future, water pipeline main-



tenance and other things," Verma said. Another aspect of the plan would be decentralisation and privatisation of the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) distribution network.

"Within the next one year we will float tenders inviting big private players for management of each of DJB's existing eight command centres. In future these companies will be given each of the zones, and they will be responsible for managing all the major operations in

those areas," the minister said, according to a statement. Under the plan, each of the companies will be tasked with the job of repairing and replacing old water pipes, billing and revenue collection, and regular water supply.

According to an official, "The DJB has already started working on the Chandrawal WTP command centre under which water supply infrastructure improvement, including replacement of

old lines, providing house service connections, upgradation of Underground Reservoirs (UGRs), etc., have already been awarded and are in progress."

Tenders will be floated soon for the East, North-East, West and South-West zones, for which detailed project reports are being prepared, the person said.

Delhi is a largely urbanised city with a huge and growing concentration of population, which requires being serviced with a water supply and sewage treatment.

In 2016, the Delhi government came up with a Delhi Water Policy with an outlook for the next nine years.

"Besides increasing the water supply, we are also studying ways to reduce the losses during transmission. We are also studying previous DJB reports and studies and preparing the new, comprehensive master plan for the future. These insights will be used to develop a long-term plan," Singh said.

CM Rekha inaugurates development projects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday inaugurated several key development projects in the Shalimar Bagh Assembly constituency. In addition, the Chief Minister inaugurated the remodelling of existing stormwater drains on Bhagwan Mahavir Marg and K. L. Bagga Marg. Under this project, precast factory-manufactured RCC drains will be constructed in line with the New Master Drain Plan 2025.

The work is expected to further strengthen the drainage system in the area and reduce problems during the rainy season.

She also carried out surprise inspections of ongoing works in the area and instructed officials to ensure quality and timely completion. The Chief Minister said these initiatives would help reduce waterlogging during the monsoon while also strengthening roads and the surrounding infrastructure.



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta during the inauguration ceremony of 'Ayushman Arogya Mandir' in Shalimar Bagh, New Delhi

PTI

Among the projects launched was the remodelling of the stormwater drain on Haiderpur Main Road, stretching from the bus stand to DA Block in Shalimar Bagh. The work is being carried out under the New Master Drain Plan 2025, which involves constructing RCC drains to improve the area's drainage system.

During her visit, Gupta also reviewed the progress of

several projects related to infrastructure development, drainage systems and public amenities. She said drainage improvement works have also been initiated on Road number 319, RUB Shalimar Bagh, Chaudhary Mehr Chand Marg, Road number 320 and Swami Shradhdhan and Saraswati Marg.

To streamline traffic movement in the area, the Chief Minister also launched the

construction of a slip road at Shalimar Chowk and the development of a U-turn facility near the RUB. This initiative is expected to ease traffic pressure in the area and provide smoother and safer movement for residents and commuters.

The chief minister also inaugurated an Ayushman Arogya Mandir at the Sahipur village chaul. The centre is expected to play an important role in providing primary health-care services to residents and improving access to basic medical facilities at the local level. Along with inaugurating these projects, the Chief Minister also conducted a surprise inspection of the ongoing road widening and drainage improvement work at Singapur Labour Chowk in Shalimar Bagh.

During the inspection, the chief minister sought detailed updates from officials present at the site and directed them to ensure quality, transparency and timely execution of the development works.

DU dismisses Rahul's allegation that it uses interviews to eliminate students

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi University (DU) has dismissed Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's allegation that it uses interviews to eliminate students. In a post on X late on Friday, it said, "The University of Delhi admits students primarily based on the CUET scores, and the standard admission process does not mandate interviews for most undergraduate and postgraduate programmes."

"If the Leader of Opposition was referring to recruitments (such as faculty positions), the university in the recent past has recruited thousands of teachers across all categories. We strongly object to such comments, as they create a non-conducive environment in the university. The Leader of Opposition should have verified the facts before making such a statement. @EduMinOfIndia," it



added. This was in response to the remarks of Rahul Gandhi, the leader of opposition in the Lok Sabha, alleging that the DU eliminates students on the basis of caste.

"I had gone to Delhi University. An interview is just a way to eliminate students. They ask what your caste is and then you fail in the interview," Rahul said on Friday while addressing an event in Lucknow to mark the birth anniversary of Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) founder Kanshi Ram. He also said that Kanshi Ram spoke of equality in society. "If Jawaharlal Nehru

were alive today, Kanshi Ram would have been Congress's chief minister. But today, the BJP has divided society into 15 per cent and 85 per cent, with benefits going only to the 15 per cent and 50 per cent of people being marginalised."

Targeting the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), the Congress leader further said, "Take out the list of the RSS. Those who are their pracharaks and seniors in the organisation, you will not find one OBC, one Dalit, or one Adivasi among them. This is completely against the Constitution."

Man arrested for stabbing youth

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police have arrested a 19-year-old man for allegedly stabbing a youth in Model Town after being confronted by the victim's family over harassing a woman in the neighbourhood.

The accused, identified as Shyam Sunder alias Shyamlal, a resident of Rajpura Gurmandi in north Delhi, was apprehended within hours of the incident on Friday, the police said.

According to police, the case came to light after the woman complained that Shyam, who lived in her neighbourhood, had been harassing her for some time and making lewd gestures whenever she passed by.

She warned him to stop and threatened to inform her husband and brother if his behaviour continued, they said.



"In response, the accused allegedly threatened the woman that if she disclosed the matter to anyone, he would kill her husband and brother," a senior police officer said.

On Thursday at 8.30 pm, Shyam allegedly attacked the woman's brother, stabbing him three to four times before fleeing the spot, the police said. A case was registered under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita on Friday, and an investigation was launched, they said.

Nilgai, jackal die at Delhi zoo

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A male nilgai and a jackal have died within three days of each other at the National Zoological Park. These deaths, which occurred on March 10 and March 12, follow similar incidents over the last few months that have drawn attention to animal health and monitoring protocols.

According to an official, the nilgai was found dead in Beat No. 1 of the zoo. The jackal was reported dead from Beat No. 10.

Zoo director Sanjeet Kumar said the deaths were due to old age. He said both animals had been under observation and preliminary findings indicated age-related complications.

These incidents occurred within three months of other fatalities at the zoo, including a female antelope, a jackal and a Sangai deer.

Earlier this month, a male Sangai deer -- a Schedule I



species under the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972 -- died at the facility.

The official said the animal had a plaster on its hind limb and required constant monitoring and veterinary care. The zoo also recorded the death of a female antelope earlier this year, he said.

In a separate incident in December 2025, a jackal was spotted inside the zoo premises on December 14, following which authorities ordered its capture. The animal allegedly died of suffocation.

The zoo union had

claimed the animal was found dead and partially burnt on December 18 after a foul smell was noticed. However, an inquiry report later found no evidence to suggest a jackal had died inside the bear enclosure, though the zoo union maintained that the carcass was disposed of without a medical examination.

In another incident, a two-year-old white tigress named Durga suffered a fracture on March 2 while being prepared for transfer to Patna Zoo under an animal exchange programme.

IN FOCUS



Supporter holds a portrait of Prime Minister Narendra Modi during a rally at Brigade Parade Ground in Kolkata

PTI

PM accuses TMC of opposing SIR to shield infiltrators

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday accused the ruling TMC of opposing the SIR exercise to “protect its vote bank of infiltrators”, alleging that unchecked illegal immigration under its rule had altered the demographic balance in several parts of West Bengal.

Addressing a rally at the Brigade Parade Ground, Modi launched a sharp attack on the State’s ruling party, accusing it of encouraging infiltration, changing the demography of the State and insulting constitutional institutions, while asserting that the “countdown has begun” for the Mamata Banerjee Government ahead of the Assembly polls. He claimed that in many places “demography has changed”, Bengali Hindus were “deliberately being made minorities”, and alleged that the TMC opposed granting citizenship to persecuted Hindu refugees. The prime minister said the ruling party feared the



PM Narendra Modi being garlanded by West Bengal BJP President Samik Bhattacharya, LoP in the State Assembly Suwendu Adhikari during a rally in Kolkata

PTI

SIR exercise because it would remove the names of illegal voters.

“These people oppose SIR so that the names of infiltrators cannot be removed from the voter list, and the voter list cannot be purified. They are not even ready to remove the names of those who have already died,” Modi said. Claiming that infiltration had

become a major security and political issue in Bengal, he alleged that the TMC Government had encouraged the phenomenon for electoral gains. “Due to unchecked infiltration by the TMC, the demography of Bengal has changed in many areas. The TMC is deliberately making Hindus a minority in many areas,” Modi alleged. According to

official data released after the revision exercise, 63.66 lakh names, around 8.3 per cent of the electorate, have been deleted since the process began in November last year, reducing the voter base in the State from about 7.66 crore to just over 7.04 crore.

In addition, over 60.06 lakh electors have been placed under the “under adjudication” category, meaning their eligibility will be determined through legal scrutiny in the coming weeks.

He also accused the ruling party of opposing citizenship for Hindu refugees who had fled religious persecution in neighbouring countries. “When it comes to giving citizenship to persecuted Hindu refugees, the TMC opposes it because they do not consider them their vote bank,” the prime minister said.

The voter list revision exercise and the issue of infiltration have emerged as key political flashpoints in Bengal ahead of the assembly elections, with the BJP accusing the TMC of protecting

illegal immigrants, while the ruling party has alleged that the process is aimed at disenfranchising genuine voters.

Sharpening his attack on the Mamata Banerjee Government, Modi alleged that the State administration functioned with the support of criminal elements.

“The TMC Government runs on the support of goons and criminals. Extortion and cut money are their sources of income. To strengthen such gangs, they bring infiltrators. Because of infiltration, Bengal’s bread, daughters and land are under threat,” he alleged.

The prime minister also accused the TMC of targeting constitutional institutions, including the Election Commission, over the voter roll revision exercise.

“The TMC is busy attacking constitutional institutions like the Election Commission. This is shameful,” he said.

In a strong political message ahead of the Assembly elections, Modi declared that the days of the ruling party were numbered.

Delhi Govt caps commercial LPG supply at 20% amidst shortage

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

As cooking gas becomes harder to procure, hotels are being forced to switch to firewood stoves and reduce food items in their menus. The Delhi Government issued an order on Saturday, capping the daily regulated distribution of commercial LPG cylinders at roughly 20 per cent of the city’s average consumption.

In another order, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) on Saturday said consumers with Piped Natural Gas (PNG) connections will no longer be allowed to retain, obtain or refill domestic LPG cylinders under an amended supply order.

The directive follows instructions from the MoPNG and intends to ensure that essential services continue to receive fuel amid the escalating military conflict between Iran and the US that has put international supply routes in distress.

“In compliance with the directions of the MoPNG, Government of India, to make available up to 20 per



cent of the average daily commercial LPG cylinder consumption in Delhi, and in coordination with the three Oil Marketing Companies, the Delhi Government has issued a detailed policy note for distribution of commercial cooking gas during the present scarcity situation,” reads the order.

“Delhi typically records a daily sale of around 9,000 commercial LPG cylinders (19-kg equivalent). Under the new system, approximately 1,800 cylinders per day will be distributed through a priority-based allocation mechanism coordinated with the three oil marketing companies

(OMCs),” said the order issued by the Department of Food, Supplies and Consumer Affairs.

Under the distribution framework, sectors have been classified into eight priority categories. Educational institutions, hospitals, railways and airports have been placed in the highest priority bracket and will be supplied up to 100 per cent of their requirement due to the essential nature of their services,” the order said, adding that government departments and public sector institutions operating canteens fall under the second priority category.

Restaurants and eateries, which represent one of the largest commercial consumers, have been allotted the largest share at 42 per cent of the regulated supply. Under the policy, hotels, hospitality units and guest houses have been assigned a smaller quota, while dairies, bakeries and sweet shops also feature among the higher consumption categories.

Caterers and banquet halls, along with sectors such as dry cleaning,

packaging units, pharmaceutical units and sports facilities, have been included in subsequent priority groups.

“Supplies will be strictly based on booking requests made by consumers through the respective OMC systems. Where immediate delivery is not possible, distribution will follow a first-in-first-out system,” the order said.

Officials said these alternatives could help ease pressure on commercial LPG demand. It will remain in effect during the current period of supply constraints, with authorities monitoring distribution and demand patterns across sectors, the order added.

Meanwhile, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas on Saturday issued an order that anyone who has a Piped Natural Gas (PNG) connection, along with a domestic LPG connection, is not permitted to retain the LPG connection or obtain refills from any Government oil company or its distributors.

UP Govt forms SIT to probe killings of two senior officials at biogas plant in Budaun

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

The Uttar Pradesh Government has constituted a special investigation team (SIT) to probe the killing of two senior officials at a compressed biogas plant in Budaun, following directions from Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath.

According to an official statement, the SIT has been formed under the chairmanship of the Bareilly division-



al commissioner and will conduct a detailed investigation into all aspects of the incident to ensure a fair and transparent probe. The chief

minister said swift action had already been taken in the case, and the main accused had been arrested. He added that if the probe reveals any larger conspiracy or involvement of other individuals, strict action will be taken in line with the Government’s “zero tolerance” policy towards crime and criminals.

Authorities have also strengthened security at the plant and established a police outpost inside the biogas plant premises to prevent

any such incidents in the future and ensure the safety of industrial establishments, the statement said.

Meanwhile, the state government on Friday night transferred the Senior Superintendent of Police of Budaun, Brijesh Kumar Singh, to Lucknow and appointed him as superintendent of police (logistics). He has been replaced by Ankita Sharma, who was serving as the superintendent of police of Kasganj.

CM Nitish launches ₹480 crore projects

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Begusarai/Sheikhpura

Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar on Saturday launched several development projects and schemes worth around ₹480 crore in Begusarai and Sheikhpura districts during his ‘Samridhi Yatra’.

The CM also reviewed ongoing schemes and development projects in both districts. According to a statement issued by the Chief Minister’s Office, “The CM launched more than 400 development projects/schemes worth ₹274 crore in Begusarai.

These include the inauguration of 211 projects/schemes worth ₹165 crore and laying the foundation stones for 189



projects/schemes worth ₹109 crore.”

The CM also inspected the under-construction government medical college and hospital in Begusarai. During the

inspection, the chief minister reviewed the progress of the construction work and instructed officials to ensure that the construction is completed within the stipulated time frame.

Once the hospital is completed, people in the surrounding areas will be able to receive better and timely medical treatment, said the CM. Kumar also visited various units located in the Begusarai Industrial Area. The CM said that the Government is actively promoting the establishment of industrial units across the State.

Before the CM arrived in Begusarai, a stray bull created an unexpected scene at the helipad. A purported video of the incident went viral on social media.

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Congress creating panic amid global conflicts...

“Just as the Congress left the Northeast on its own, in a similar way, it played a major role in weakening the Barak Valley. When India became Independent, Congress allowed a border to be drawn that cut off Barak Valley’s access to the sea,” he alleged.

“Barak Valley, once known as an industrial centre, was stripped of its very strength. For decades after Independence, Congress governments remained in power, yet the region saw little development. Today, the BJP Government is working to change that,” he added. Modi said connectivity is being developed in the Barak Valley to link it to other parts of the Northeast and West Bengal.

“It will be developed as a big logistics and trade hub of the region,” he said, noting that Barak Valley is also at the centre of the Government’s Act East Policy and will be a bridge connecting India with Southeast Asia.

The PM alleged that Congress misguided Assam’s youth into paths of violence and terrorism, while the BJP has ensured the State becomes a place of unlimited opportunities where they can reach for the sky. “Where Congress stops thinking, we start working,” he said, noting that the BJP’s mantra is to give priority to those left behind in development.

“Assam’s youth have immense opportunities in the semiconductor and technology sectors. The current era of peace and progress has been achieved through immense sacrifices, which must be protected from regressive forces,” he said. The PM said that during the Congress rule, the border villages were considered the “last villages”, but his Government views them as the nation’s “first villages”. “The second phase of the Vibrant Village Program has begun from the Cachar district and is already bringing visible improvements to border areas. The historical neglect of these areas is now being replaced by proactive development and strategic focus,” he said. Referring to former PM Manmohan Singh, Modi said he represented Assam for 10 years but did not give a single paise to the farmers of the State, whereas the BJP has given them more than ₹20,000 crore. “The region’s journey of progress

is now unstoppable, supported by its rich language and culture. The development projects inaugurated today are just the beginning of a new era for the Barak Valley,” he said. Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma and Union Minister Sarbananda Sonowal were among those present at the programme.

LPG crisis: Commercial cylinder distribution...

Based on our requirements, we produce adequate petrol and diesel domestically and do not need to import,” she said. She further stated that despite the prevailing geopolitical situation, no fuel shortage has been reported.

“The number of bookings was about 75.7 lakh on Thursday, and it has now increased to around 88 lakh on Saturday. This is nothing but panic booking,” the official said, urging consumers to book cylinders only when required. Pre-war, daily bookings totalled around 55 lakh and oil marketing companies delivered 50 lakh cylinders per day. While the cylinder deliveries remain the same, bookings have surged,” Sharma said.

There are 101469 retail outlets, and 25605 LPG distributors in the country. The Government says around 50 lakh domestic LPG cylinders are delivered on a daily basis. There are 33.37 crore LPG consumers, while PNG consumers stood at 1.5 crore. “The first day we informed you about a 10 per cent increase in domestic production, then 25 per cent, then 28 per cent, and today the increase has reached 31 per cent,” she said.

As part of supply management measures, the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) has allowed the temporary use of biomass and RDF pellets in place of natural gas and LPG by industries, hotels, restaurants and other establishments in the National Capital Region, including Delhi, for a period of one month.

Consumers have been urged to use digital tools such as SMS, WhatsApp and mobile apps of OMCs for refill bookings instead of visiting LPG distributorships. “There is no need to stand in queues at distributorships for booking or cylinder delivery. OMCs deliver cylinders to consumers’ homes and will continue to do so,” she

said. State Governments and district administrations have been asked to closely monitor the LPG supply situation and ensure smooth distribution, she said, adding that several chief ministers and senior officials have already held review meetings in States such as Haryana, Goa, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh.

Authorities have also intensified enforcement to curb hoarding and black-marketing, with states conducting raids and surprise inspections in coordination with Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs). The Ministry issued an advisory assuring citizens that petrol and diesel remain adequately available across the country. It also urged people to avoid unsafe practices such as storing petrol or diesel in loose containers.

“It has come to notice that at one retail outlet in Tamil Nadu, petrol was being taken in a loose container, which is unsafe and not advisable,” the ministry said. The ministry added that strict action has already been taken in the matter.

India imports 88 per cent of its crude oil needs, 50 per cent of its natural gas requirement and 60 per cent of its LPG demand. Before the US and Israel attacked Iran on February 28, and Tehran retaliated by hitting US bases in neighbouring countries as well as Israel, more than half of the crude oil requirement came from the Middle East countries, 30 per cent of gas from the region and 85-90 per cent of LPG. The war has led to an effective blockage of the Strait of Hormuz, which is the usual sea transit for energy from the Gulf countries. While India has managed to source crude oil from other countries, including Russia, the hit on gas supply has led to cuts for industrial users and to commercial establishments such as hotels and restaurants.

HC tells UP officials: Quit if you can’t enforce law

The State has disputed the ownership of Gata No 291 by saying that this is reflected in the names of Mohan Singh and Bhooraj Singh, both sons of Sukhi Singh, in the revenue records.

However, permission was granted only to the extent of 20 worshippers who may offer namaz, whereas the petitioner says a larger number of

people may come for prayers as it is the month of Ramzan. Counsel for the State said that on account of the perceived law and order situation, such an order restricting the number of worshippers was passed. After hearing counsels for the parties, the court said, “It is the duty of the State to ensure that the rule of law prevails under every circumstance. If the local authorities, ie Superintendent of Police and Collector, feel that the law and order situation could arise because of which they want to limit the number of worshippers within the premises, they should either resign from their post or seek transfer outside Sambhal.” The court fixed March 16 for the next hearing.

Trump urges nations to help secure Strait of Hormuz

Iran on Saturday threatened for the first time to attack the infrastructure of a neighbouring country, urging people to evacuate three major ports in the United Arab Emirates it claimed the US military was using to launch strikes on Iran.

The warning sharpens fears of an escalating war on the vital infrastructure for global energy supplies, as the Strait of Hormuz remains effectively closed.

Iran has fired hundreds of missiles and drones at Gulf neighbours, saying it targets US assets even as airports and oil facilities have been hit or threatened. America and Israel have struck thousands of targets across Iran during the war, now in its third week.

On Friday, President Donald Trump said US forces “obliterated” military sites on Iran’s Kharg Island, home to the country’s main oil export terminal, prompting Iranian officials to warn of further retaliation. Meanwhile, Israel’s war against Hezbollah has deepened Lebanon’s humanitarian crisis, with about 800 people killed and more than 8,50,000 displaced.

Sonam Wangchuk walks free as Govt revokes...

In Leh, Ladakh MP Mohamad Hanifa hailed Wangchuk’s release and urged the Government

to accept their demands for statehood and protection under the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution. “We welcome the release of Sonam Wangchuk. But others also need to be released, and the Government should also take back the cases filed against people who participated in the protests,” Hanifa said.

Hanifa, however, said protest is a Constitutional right, and urged the Government to resolve the issue through dialogue.

LAB co-chairman Chering Dorjee said the Government “saved its face” by revoking Wangchuk’s detention ahead of the Supreme Court hearing later this month, asserting that the peaceful struggle for statehood for Ladakh and its inclusion in the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution will continue. Kargil-based politician and Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA) member Sajjad Kargili, in a post on X, demanded the immediate release of Deldan Namgial and Smanla Dorjee, and appealed to the Government to drop all charges against other detainees unconditionally.

“The revocation of the NSA against Shri Sonam Wangchuk is a welcome move. However, the struggle for our legitimate rights continues,” he said.

“This is not just about Wangchuk but about the whole of Ladakh. We had maintained from the start that the allegations against him, including the anti-national charge, were baseless. Today, Ladakh stands vindicated. We welcome the decision, and it will give fresh momentum to our movement,” Dorjee told reporters.

Calling the development a major relief, he said the people of Ladakh felt hurt by the anti-national allegations made against them. “We are among the most nationalist people in the country, yet we were branded anti-national for the first time. It was a serious blot on Ladakh... We believe the case was withdrawn before the March 17 hearing as the same outcome was expected from the Supreme Court,” the LAB leader said.

Dorjee said their main demands remained unchanged and the struggle would continue, asserting that the group will take a call on the proposed protest rally in both Leh and Kargil on March 16 in the wake of an appeal by Chief Secretary Ashish Kundra.

Akasa Air joins Air India, IndiGo in levying fuel surcharge

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Air travelers are set to face higher ticket costs from Sunday. After Air India group and IndiGo moved to pass on part of the fuel cost burden to passengers, Akasa Air on Saturday announced to levy fuel surcharge between ₹199 and ₹1,300 on its domestic and international flights from Sunday. There has been a significant increase in the price of aviation turbine fuel, driven by evolving geopolitical developments in the Middle East.

Akasa's decision comes after larger Indian carriers Air India Group and IndiGo also moved to pass on part of the fuel cost burden to passengers. The airline said the change would apply to both domestic and international flights starting March 15.

"With oil prices skyrocketing, rupees crashing to new lows every day, longer routes due to airspace restrictions and uncertainty of schedules, costs have reached a tipping point for airlines," said an aviation expert defending the hike.

In a post on X, the airline said it will levy fuel surcharges ranging from ₹199 to



₹1,300 on domestic and international flight tickets from March 15 due to the spike in jet fuel prices amid the West Asia conflict.

The airline said the surcharge will apply to all bookings made from 00:01 hrs on March 15, 2026, and will not be applicable to tickets booked before that time.

The airline said the additional charge will be levied per sector and will vary depending on the duration of the flight. "There has been a significant increase in the price of aviation turbine fuel, driven by evolving geopolitical developments in the Middle East," Akasa Air said in its statement. "As fuel repre-

sents a significant portion of airline operating costs, this impacts the cost of operations across the aviation industry," it added.

The airline said it remains focused on offering "warm and efficient customer service, reliable operations, and affordable fares while maintaining the highest standards of operational efficiency", and added that it will continue to monitor the operating environment and review the fuel surcharge periodically. The announcement comes less than a day after IndiGo introduced a fuel surcharge range between ₹425 and ₹2,300 per passenger,

depending on the route and distance of travel. IndiGo said it has opted for a "relatively smaller amount" rather than trying to offload the full shock of the surging aviation turbine fuel price.

Air India has also announced a phased expansion of fuel surcharges on both domestic and international routes due to the steep rise in jet fuel prices.

The airline noted in a statement that ATF (which accounts for nearly 40 per cent of its operating costs) has witnessed a significant price escalation since early March 2026 due to supply interruptions.

According to the statement, the new fuel surcharge will be implemented in three phases. It will apply to travel on all flights — including those operated by Air India Express.

Attacks on commercial shipping and oil infrastructure in the Gulf region, along with disruption through the Strait of Hormuz, have tightened supplies and driven a steep increase in fuel prices. Airlines are also facing added operational costs due to airspace restrictions and longer rerouted flights, which burn more fuel.

Modi Govt sacrificing agriculture for its own interests: Rahul Gandhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi alleged on Saturday that the BJP-led Government has not honoured its promises made to farmers and is prepared to sacrifice India's agriculture for its own interest.

In a Facebook post, the leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha shared a question he asked in the House recently regarding announcing a minimum support price for crops and whether the trade agreement with the United States would change the Narendra Modi Government's existing MSP policy.

"In the Lok Sabha, I asked a direct question to the Government: Why has the promise of a statutory MSP — calculated at C2+50 per cent — made to farmers in 2021, not yet been implemented?"

"Evading a direct response, the Government merely reiterated its existing MSP policy. The Government also admitted to pressuring states to discontinue MSP bonuses — a move it sought to justify, without any logical



Rahul Gandhi

basis, in the name of 'national priorities'," Gandhi said in his post in Hindi. He said another critical question is whether the trade agreement with the US speaks of reducing "non-trade barriers". "Does this imply an intent to undermine the MSP mechanism and Government procurement?" the Congress leader asked. "The Government is evading this question as well," he claimed.

"The Modi Government not only refuses to honour the promises made to farmers, but it is also prepared to sacrifice Indian agriculture for the sake of its own interest," Gandhi alleged in his post.

"We will continue to raise our voices — both inside and outside Parliament — to defend farmers' rights and protect the MSP," the Congress leader asserted.

Unified BRICS position on West Asia elusive, admits MEA



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India on Saturday admitted that a common BRICS position on the West Asia conflict remains elusive due to "differing views" among member nations, and New Delhi is engaged to forge a consensus on the issue.

Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal, without naming any country, said some BRICS members are directly involved in the conflict, which has impacted finding a unified stance for the grouping. India is the current chair of the influential bloc, which recently expanded to include Iran, the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and some other countries.

Iran's counter-offensive against the UAE and other Gulf nations following the February 28 US-Israel strikes on Iranian targets has triggered some disquiet within the grouping.

As the current chair of the BRICS, India is now navigating the challenge of finding a common position for the bloc on the conflict.

"Some members of the BRICS are directly involved in the current situation in the West Asia region, which has impacted forging a consensus on a common BRICS position on the ongoing conflict," Jaiswal said at a media briefing.

RSS calls for unity against divisive forces: Hosabale

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

RSS general secretary Dattatreya Hosabale on Saturday said that several divisive forces are trying to fracture the social psyche based on class and caste, and gave a call for unity in society and the country.

Paying tributes to Sant Ravidas on his 650th birth anniversary year, Hosabale said he holds a distinct position in India's "illustrious tradition of saints." While rejecting birth-based discrimination, he considered deeds as the only testimony of greatness, the RSS second-in-command noted.

Sant Ravidas played a "historical role" in shaping the social mindset for getting rid of dogmas and outdated customs, shedding the irrelevant traditions and accepting social transformations in tune with the changing times, he said.



RSS general secretary Dattatreya Hosabale

"In present times, when several divisive forces are trying to fracture the social psyche based on class and caste, all of us need to resolve to work towards the unity and integrity of the society and the nation by understanding the essence of Poojya Sant Ravidas ji's life message," Hosabale said.

Highlighting the importance of the Sant tradition in shaping India's

spiritual and social life, Hosabale said it has not only played a key role in strengthening devotion and social harmony but also awakened and prepared society for the struggle against the oppression of foreign rulers.

Hosabale claimed that several attempts were made by Muslim invaders to convert Ravidas to Islam, but they failed, and many of them later became his disciples. "There were several attempts to convert Sant Ravidas ji to Islam, but after witnessing Sant Ravidas ji's devotion and spiritual prowess, those who wanted to convert him became his disciples," Hosabale said at Madhav Srishti in Haryana's Samalkha, where the Akhil Bharatiya Pratinidhi Sabha is being held from March 13 to 15.

The RSS leader also emphasised that Ravidas's life reflected the dignity of labour and moral conduct.

"He re-established the dignity of labour and pure, virtuous and transparent conduct in society through his own life," Hosabale said.

He further said Ravidas's greatness was acknowledged across sections of society despite his humble origins and noted that several prominent figures, including Meerabai, regarded him as their guru.

Sant Ravidas was a prominent Bhakti movement saint of the 15th century, revered for his teachings on devotion, equality and social harmony. Born in Seer Govardhanpur near Varanasi in a humble family traditionally associated with leather work, he challenged caste-based discrimination and stressed that a person's deeds determine greatness rather than birth. Considering the importance of his thoughts, his 41 vanis (compositions) have been included in the Shri Guru Granth Sahib in the form of 'Shabad'.

Activists divided after SC declines plea on menstrual leave

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Lawyers and activists have expressed varied views after the Supreme Court of India declined to entertain a plea seeking a nationwide menstrual leave policy, with some backing voluntary provisions while others stressing stronger legal safeguards to protect women's health and dignity.

The apex court on Friday refused to entertain the PIL, observing that no one would give them jobs in such a scenario and that such a provision would unintentionally reinforce gender stereotypes.

Talking to mediapersons, senior advocate Karuna Nundy said a limited provision, such as one paid day of menstrual leave, could be a practical starting point. "The range of menstrual pain,

from common cramps to endometriosis, is suffered by women regardless of whether they are studying or working. So the policies should address the woman's health challenge and the variable context," she said.

"One paid day of menstrual leave, to be taken as required, would be a good start. It's like maternity leave, if you don't have a baby, don't take the leave, but you shouldn't have to pretend to be a pain-free hero when you have a cycle that literally allows the human race to perpetuate itself," Nundy added.

Activist Yogita Bhayana criticised the concerns that menstrual leave could reduce women's employment opportunities.

"This is very stupid of them to think like that. Women already deal with biological realities like pregnancy and



childcare. If you deny them opportunities because of that, you should rather guide or dictate to corporates not to hamper jobs," Bhayana told media.

Bhayana said many women face severe pain during menstruation and should be given the option to take leave. "There are women who suffer severe pain and cannot focus on

work. Even if they report to the office, productivity is very low that day. A voluntary option for leave should definitely be given," she said.

She also said such provisions should extend to students. "Students also go through the same pain. Sometimes, even sitting in class becomes difficult, and you cannot focus on your studies. So a voluntary

option should be available for them as well," she said.

Bhayana added that Governments should encourage voluntary policies even if courts have stepped back from the issue.

"Governments should take a stand and encourage voluntary policies. If the court has declined, State Governments should come forward and make it happen. Women are not asking for it for fun; it is a practical issue," she said.

Bhayana said providing a voluntary option for leave would be a practical solution. "There are some women who don't get pain, and they don't need leave. Let it be voluntary. But denying everyone the option is wrong," Bhayana said.

Ranjana Kumari, an activist, said the issue largely falls within the domain of State Governments.

Healthcare sector has undergone transformative expansion in last decade: Nadda

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Under the Leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India's healthcare sector has undergone transformative expansion in infrastructure, medical education and access to affordable care in the last decade, Union Health Minister JP Nadda said on Saturday.

Addressing the convocation ceremony of Teerthanker Mahaveer University in Moradabad, Nadda said that in the last eleven years, India has witnessed a significant expansion of premier medical institutions.

"The number of All India Institute of Medical Sciences has increased from six earlier to 23 today, strengthening tertiary healthcare services and

creating new opportunities for high-quality medical education and research across the country," he said.

Highlighting the transformative changes in India's healthcare sector over the past decade, Nadda said, "The Government has made sustained efforts to expand healthcare infrastructure, strengthen medical education and improve access to affordable and quality healthcare across the country under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi."

Nadda noted that India has recorded substantial progress in improving maternal and child health outcomes.

Citing global estimates, he stated that India's maternal mortality ratio has declined by about 86 per cent, com-



Union Minister JP Nadda (second left) during the convocation ceremony of the Teerthanker University in Moradabad on Saturday

pared to a global reduction of around 48 per cent, reflecting the impact of sustained public health interventions.

Speaking about India's efforts to eliminate Tuberculosis, he highlighted that India has achieved a 21

per cent decline in TB incidence, which is significantly higher than the global decline of 12 per cent, as reported by the WHO.

Nadda further emphasised that the Government has been working consistently

to reduce the financial burden of healthcare on citizens. He noted that out-of-pocket expenditure (OOPE) on healthcare has significantly declined from 62.6 per cent to 39.4 per cent, reflecting the Government's commitment to making healthcare more affordable and accessible to the people.

Highlighting India's progress in strengthening access to timely treatment, Nadda cited findings from The Lancet, noting that around 90 per cent of cancer patients in India begin their treatment within 20 days, reflecting improvements in early diagnosis and treatment pathways across the healthcare system.

He also highlighted the transformative impact of Ayushman Bharat Pradhan

Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana, describing it as the world's largest health coverage scheme, which provides health coverage of up to Rs 5 lakh per family for secondary and tertiary care hospitalisation.

Nadda stated that the scheme has significantly expanded financial protection in healthcare and has benefited more than 71 crore people, enabling millions of families to access quality treatment without financial hardship.

Addressing the gathering, the Union health minister noted that a convocation marks not only the completion of an academic journey but also the beginning of a new chapter of responsibility and service.

Nation Focus



TWO NEW SPECIES OF LICHEN MOTHS DISCOVERED, SAYS BHUPENDRA YADAV

Union Environment Minister Bhupendra Yadav on Saturday said scientists at the Zoological Survey of India have announced the discovery of two new species of lichen moths. "The discovery of Caulocera Hollowayi and Asura Buxa is a vital contribution to the documentation of India's moth biodiversity," the minister wrote in a social media post.

He said this success underscores the necessity of sustained taxonomic efforts in biodiversity hotspots like the Himalayas. The findings, published in the prestigious international taxonomic journal Zootaxa, document seven new species records of lichen from India in the same publication.

Lauding the contribution, Dhriti Banerjee, Director of the Zoological Survey of India, said, "Research into evolutionarily significant and lesser-known groups like Lepidoptera is essential for understanding ecosystem functioning and air pollution indicator species of the Indian Himalaya." The team has identified these species — Caulocerahollowayi, S Singh, N Singh and Bhattacharya, 2026 and Asurabuxa Bhattacharya, S Singh and N Singh, 2026 — from specimens collected near Golitar, Sikkim and Panijhora, West Bengal, respectively.



SIT FORMED TO PROBE ASSASSINATION ATTEMPT ON FAROOQ ABDULLAH

Jammu and Kashmir Police have constituted a seven-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) to probe the recent assassination attempt on former chief minister and National Conference chief Farooq Abdullah during a marriage function.

Inspector General of Police, Bhim Sen Tuti ordered the setting up of the SIT, considering the "seriousness and sensitivity" of the case.

On Wednesday night, Abdullah had a miraculous escape when a gunman opened fire on him after coming from behind while he was leaving a marriage function at Royal Park Banquet Hall in the Greater Kailash area.

The 63-year-old accused, identified as Kamal Singh, was overpowered and arrested on the spot. A revolver used in the crime was recovered from his possession.

India engaging key players for energy security



External Affairs Ministry Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Against the backdrop of spiralling hostilities in West Asia, India on Saturday said it has remained in touch with all key players, including the Gulf Cooperation Council, Iran, the US and Israel, with a primary focus on safeguarding its energy security.

External Affairs Ministry Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said that besides advocating for dialogue and diplomacy, India has consistently underlined the necessity of ensuring the unimpeded transit of goods and energy supplies through the region.

Aseem Mahajan, an additional secretary in the ministry, said five Indian nationals have lost their lives and one remains missing in the ongoing conflict. He said around 1,72,000 Indians have returned to India since February 28, the day the hostilities began.

"We have also called for avoiding targeting civilian infrastructure, including energy infrastructure, across the region. We believe that these are the priorities of a large part of the global community since the impact of the conflict is being felt globally," Jaiswal said.

Global oil and gas prices have surged after Iran has virtually blocked the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow shipping lane between the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman, that handles roughly 20 per cent of global oil and LNG (Liquefied Natural Gas).

West Asia has been a major source of India's energy procurement.

"As you would be aware, we are dealing with a very complex situation concerning the active conflict zone," Jaiswal said. "Nevertheless, we have remained in touch with all important interlocutors, including all the Gulf Cooperation Council members, Iran, the US and Israel at various political and diplomatic levels in an effort to take up with them and underline our priorities, especially concerning our energy security," he said.

Both Jaiswal and Mahajan made the remarks at a media briefing.

The external affairs ministry spokesperson also made a mention of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's phone conversations with a number of his counterparts in West Asia in the last few days. The external affairs minister and our embassies have also been in close touch with their interlocutors, he said.

States Focus



MASSIVE SEARCH OPERATION IN J&K'S SAMBA AFTER PAK DRONE SPOTTED

A massive search operation was launched by security forces on Saturday in several forward villages of Jammu and Kashmir's Samba district after a Pakistani drone crossed the International Border and entered the Indian territory, officials said. The enemy drone movement was noticed for a few minutes over the villages of Kandral, Abtal and Bahadurpur in the Ramgarh sector late Friday night, officials said. They said the area was kept under strict surveillance, and a massive search operation was launched at first light of the day to ensure that there was no air-dropping of weapons or narcotics from across the border. Security forces recovered over 3.5 kgs of heroin worth over ₹20 crore in international market after the consignments were dropped by drones in border villages in the RS Pura sector near here in the past two days. Two suspected narcotic smugglers were detained for questioning in connection with the latest recovery in the RS Pura sector on Friday.



CHHATTISGARH CM LAUNCHES GAUDHAM YOJANA FOR STRAY CATTLE

Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai on Saturday launched the Gaudham Yojana under which 1,460 shelters will be set up across the State to ensure protection and proper management of stray and abandoned cattle. Sai visited the Gaudham at Lakhasar village in Takhatpur development block, where he formally announced the launch of the scheme. He then virtually inaugurated 29 Gaudhams across 11 districts during an event held at Guru Ghasidas Central University auditorium.

Govt exposed: Congress after Wangchuk's release from jail

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The opposition parties on Saturday denounced the Centre for "completely bogus grounds" framed to keep climate activist Sonam Wangchuk in prison for almost six months and alleged that his release from jail had "exposed" the arbitrary use of the National Security Act. The Congress said the Centre should apologise not just to Wangchuk and his family, but also to the people of Ladakh. "The Indian National Congress had condemned the arrest of Sonam Wangchuk on completely bogus grounds six months back. "Now the Modi Government has done a total U-turn. It stands fully exposed. It should apologise to not only Mr Wangchuk and his family but to the people of Ladakh as well," Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said in a post on X.



Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh

FILE PHOTO

AAP National Convenor Arvind Kejriwal said the Wangchuk case mirrors the treatment meted out to his party's top leadership in the alleged Delhi liquor scam, claiming they were kept in jail "for months and years" under fabricated charges. "The Modi Government stands exposed once again. A scientist and climate activist who had dedicated his life to the nation was arrested without any evidence," Kejriwal said on X.

"The months he spent in jail were not only a personal loss for him but also a loss to the country. This sheer dictatorship must be called out and stopped immediately," the former Delhi chief minister added. Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah hailed Wangchuk's release and demanded that the government also free those arrested in the Valley during the recent anti-US and anti-Israel protests.

Release youngsters detained in valley: CM Omar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Srinagar

Welcoming the revocation of the NSA against Ladakh activist Sonam Wangchuk, Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Saturday called for the release of those arrested in the valley during the recent anti-US and anti-Israel protests.

"He should not have been arrested. His arrest was wrong, and that too under the NSA," Abdullah told reporters here on the sidelines of Spring Festival at Badamwari.

He emphasised that the situation in Ladakh should



Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah during the inauguration ceremony of Almond Blossom Festival in Srinagar on Saturday

PTI

remain stable and insisted that, just as the promises made to Jammu and Kashmir need to be fulfilled, the same applies to Ladakh. Abdullah

noted that just like Wangchuk's case, those facing minor charges or those who have spent longer in jail than their sentence would other-

wise be should be released as well.

"Given the sanctity of this holy month of Ramadan, with Eid almost a week away, it would be appropriate to extend similar consideration to others, just as was done with Wangchuk," he stated.

He urged the release of young people detained in recent protests, claiming that many of them are first-time offenders and did not actively engage in the demonstrations. "As an expression of goodwill, revoking cases against them and releasing some from jail would be a positive step," he added.

Modi Govt exposed again, Sonam Wangchuk jailed without evidence: Kejriwal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Centre's decision to revoke the detention of Ladakh-based climate activist Sonam Wangchuk after almost six months has drawn sharp reaction from the AAP, which said that it "exposes" how individuals can be jailed for months, "without evidence". AAP National Convenor or Arvind Kejriwal said the case of Wangchuk mirrors the treatment meted out to his party's top leadership in the alleged Delhi liquor

Schedule of the Constitution rocked Leh.

More than 45 people, including 22 police personnel, were injured in the protests.

He was released from a Jodhpur jail around 1.30 pm on Saturday following an order from the Centre after already undergoing nearly half of the detention period stipulated under the NSA.

Reacting to the revocation of Wangchuk's detention order, Delhi AAP chief Saurabh Bharadwaj questioned the circumstances



scam, claiming they were kept in jail "for months and years" under fabricated charges.

"The Modi Government stands exposed once again. A scientist and climate activist who had dedicated his life to the nation was arrested without any evidence," Kejriwal said in a post on X.

"The months he spent in jail were not only a personal loss for him but also a loss to the country. This sheer dictatorship must be called out and stopped immediately," he added.

Wangchuk was detained on September 26 last year under the National Security Act (NSA), two days after protests over demands for statehood for Ladakh and its inclusion under the Sixth

surrounding the detention and the delay in addressing a habeas corpus petition challenging it.

"About six months ago, a renowned scientist from Ladakh who has made countless innovations for Ladakh and the Indian Army and is known around the world for educating poor children was arrested by the Central Government under the NSA, claiming that he was a threat to national security," Bharadwaj said.

"His wife has been fighting a habeas corpus petition in the Supreme Court for months. The case had been going on for a long time, and the Central Government kept seeking new dates with different excuses," he alleged.

Shah promises anti-conversion law if BJP wins Punjab polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Home Minister Amit Shah said on Saturday that a law to check religious conversions will be brought in Punjab if the BJP forms the Government in the State after the 2027 Assembly polls. Addressing a "Badlav" rally at Moga in Punjab, Shah raised the issue of religious conversions in Punjab and said the entire state is afflicted with it.

"All of Punjab is facing the issue of religious conversions. I am saying this to all Hindu and Sikh brothers and sisters, you form the BJP Government once, we will bring a Bill to check religious conversions," he said.

Earlier this month in Mumbai, the home minister had spoken about religious conversions in Punjab and appealed to the AAP Government in the State, led by Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, to put an end to this practice driven by "greed".

Virtually ending speculation about reviving the alliance with Shiromani Akali Dal, Shah said that the BJP will fight the 2027 elections in Punjab to form its own Government. He said the BJP, in a way, has launched its poll campaign from Moga



Union Home Minister Amit Shah during the Badlav rally in Moga, Punjab

PTI

for the assembly polls early next year. "I have come to appeal to people of Punjab to give us your blessings," the Union minister said, seeking support for his party.

With the BJP earlier having been part of the Government in Punjab as a junior partner to the Akalis, Shah, without naming any party, told the gathering, "Whenever we came before you, we came in the role of a younger brother. We could not have formed the Government (on our own)".

Shah further said the ninth Sikh guru, Tegh Bahadur, had laid down his life to stop religious conversions. "From this land, I want to say this today - if Guru Tegh Bahadurji was not there, there would

not be a single Hindu left in India today. It is the sacrifice of Guru Tegh Bahadur that has sustained this country. From Guru Nanak Dev to Guru Gobind Singh, I bow my head before the gurus," Shah said.

Addressing the rally in the Killi Chahlan village, Shah said that Punjab has given many opportunities to Congress, Akalis and AAP, and should now give the BJP a chance. "We will bring change in Punjab", he said.

Shah said that in 2024, the BJP got "19 per cent votes. And it is our track record, where the BJP gets 19 per cent of the vote, and the next Government formed there is of the BJP. And this happened in Odisha, Assam, Manipur, Tripura,

Uttarakhand, and now it is the turn of Punjab".

The Shiromani Akali Dal had snapped its 24-year-old alliance with the BJP in September 2020 over the now-scrapped three farm laws. At present, the BJP has two MLAs in the 117-member House.

Prior to the end of their electoral alliance, both Akalis and the BJP used to fight together. Under their poll pact, the BJP used to contest 23 seats and the SAD 94 assembly seats. In parliamentary polls, the SAD used to fight for 10 seats, and the BJP would contest three. The SAD-BJP combine formed the Government in the state thrice - 1997-2002, 2007-12, and 2012-17.

Panun Kashmir expels Ajay Chrungoo, nominates Tito Ganju as new chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Panun Kashmir has expelled its former Chairman Ajay Chrungoo and nominated Tito Ganju as the new Chairman with immediate effect.

The decision was announced through a circular issued by Convenor Agnishekhar, following consultations with senior leaders and recommendations from the General Secretary Kuldeep Raina, Organising Secretary Beharilal Kaul, the Publicity and Media Secretary, Vice Chairman and several senior activists.

Panun Kashmir has also decided to constitute a Commission of Enquiry to examine allegations relating to foreign engagements, sponsorship of overseas visits and interactions with individuals alleged to be linked with hostile agencies.

According to the circular, serious concerns had been raised regarding the functioning of the organisation in the years following the controversial write-up associated with Ghulam Nabi Fai, a proclaimed and convicted



Panun Kashmir former chairman Ajay Chrungoo.

ISI agent. The representation cited allegations of anti-organisational conduct, deviation from ideological principles, character assassination of senior activists through proxies, attempts to dissolve the organisation without mandate, obstruction to organisational expansion, defuncting of several units and attempts to create parallel units.

The circular also referred to statements attributed to Chrungoo involving criticism of the Ram Mandir and remarks perceived by activists as hostile towards the nation, which reportedly caused deep concern

within the organisation.

Questions were also raised regarding certain foreign engagements and interactions with individuals alleged to be linked with hostile agencies, including meetings with the pro-claimed ISI agent. Clarifications were sought regarding the purpose and sponsorship of foreign visits and whether due permissions had been obtained from the competent authorities.

The leadership stated that in keeping with the principles of natural justice, senior office bearers met Chrungoo on March 14, 2025 and

apprised him of the concerns while offering him an opportunity to respond. However, he declined to provide any clarification and subsequently refused further engagement. A formal representation seeking clarification was also sent to him later, but it remained unanswered.

"In view of the seriousness of the allegations and the continued absence of clarification, it was resolved that Ajay Chrungoo stands expelled from the organisation with immediate effect," the circular stated.

The organisation further announced that Tito Ganju has been nominated as Chairman and will oversee the restructuring of the global organisational structure in accordance with the mechanism devised by the Convenor, the team nominated by him will undertake deliberations on drafting a revised constitutional framework.

An Activists' Workshop will be held in Jammu on May 24, 2026, where the proposed constitutional framework and organisational restructuring will be deliberated upon and formally adopted.

LPG crisis triggers migrant worker exodus from Kerala

TOBY ANTONY
■ Kochi

The ongoing LPG crisis, which has led to the mass closure of restaurants and hotels across Kerala, has triggered an exodus of migrant workers returning to their native places, as Ramzan approaches and elections are to be held in West Bengal and Assam.

Restaurant and hotel operators are trying to retain their staff from other States, fearing that if migrant workers leave now, they may not return until after the election.

G Jayapal, State president of the Kerala Hotel and Restaurant Association (KHRA), told PTI that migrant



workers from West Bengal and Assam were expected to return home a week before the elections in their respective States.

"However, with the LPG crisis forcing hotels and restaurants to shut down, migrant workers will start

returning to their native places early. They will return only after the elections. Also, Ramzan will be celebrated next week, and people who were working in restaurants will start returning to their states due to the lack of jobs here," he said.

Jayapal said that, in addition to exploring alternative cooking fuels, restaurant operators are also trying to prevent workers from leaving early, expecting that the LPG crisis will be resolved soon.

"A majority of the workforce in hotels and restaurants are migrant workers. Restaurants are desperate to keep them here. However, small-scale restaurant operators find it hard to maintain staff when their shops are closed," he said.

Binoy Peter of the Centre for Migration and Inclusive Development (CMID), which closely monitors migrant worker movements, told PTI that around 50 per cent of Kerala's migrant workforce comes from the poll-bound

states of Assam and West Bengal.

"With hotels closed, migrant workers in the hospitality sector have started moving to their native places. Apart from restaurant closures, the movement is also triggered by Ramzan and the elections in West Bengal and Assam. Reserved tickets in trains to these states are already in the waiting list," he said. Usually, migrant workers from Kerala return home mainly during the local body polls in their State.

However, this time, due to the SIR procedure, workers are anxious and want to cast their votes in the Assembly elections in West Bengal and Assam, Peter said. (PTI)

100 stray dogs poisoned to death in Telangana

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

In yet another incident of stray dog killings, nearly 100 canines were allegedly "poisoned to death" in Mancherla district, police said.

An animal welfare activist, A Goutham, in a complaint to police, stated that on the intervening night of March 7-8 around 100 stray dogs were killed in Kisthapur village.

The complainant, working as Cruelty Prevention Manager with the Stray Animal Foundation of India (NGO) accused that the Sarpanch and Gram Panchayath Secretary of Kisthapur village, hired two



persons and killed the stray dogs by giving poisonous injections and buried them near a river.

Based on the complaint, a case was registered under relevant sections of BNS and Prevention of Cruelty of Animals Act at Jannaram police station against the Sarpanch and Gram Panchayath, police said, adding that further investi-

gation is on. Several incidents of mass killings of stray dogs were reported from different districts in Telangana in January this year and December last year taking the toll to 1,300 following which cases were registered against Sarpanchs, their husbands, Gram Panchayat Secretaries and others based on complaints lodged by animal welfare activists.

The killings are suspected to have been carried out by some elected representatives, including Sarpanchs, allegedly to fulfill promises made to villagers ahead of gram panchayat elections held in December last year, to address the stray dog menace.

PROSPECT

Raahgiri Day returns to Delhi with #SundaysOnCycle

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The spirit of active and people-friendly streets returns to the Capital as Raahgiri Foundation, in partnership with the Fit India Movement, brings back Raahgiri Day under the nationwide #SundaysOnCycle initiative.

The event will take place on Sunday morning early from at Block-A, Connaught Place, inviting citizens to experience their streets through cycling, walking, fitness activities, and engaging community performances.

Sarika Panda Bhatt, Co-

MP Ahammad honoured with Business Bhushan Award



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

MP Ahammad, Chairman of Malabar Group, has been conferred with the prestigious Business Bhushan Award at the Lokmat Maharashtra of the Year Awards 2026, in recognition of his visionary leadership and transformative contributions to the global jewellery retail sector and society at large.

The awards ceremony, held at the iconic Gateway of India, was a confluence of leading policymakers, industry stalwarts, and eminent personalities from business and entertainment. The event witnessed the presence of Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde, and Vijay Darda, Chairman of Lokmat, along with ministers, bureaucrats, and distin-



On his arrival in Guwahati, Union Home Minister Amit Shah was welcomed by CM Himanta Biswa Sarma

Fortis Healthcare’s Adayu launches music-driven mental health care

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Adayu, Fortis Healthcare’s fully integrated in-patient mental health facility, has partnered with Sitar for Mental Health, an advocacy platform founded by neo-classical musician and sitarist Rishab Rikhiram Sharma, to promote greater awareness and dialogue around mental health.

This collaboration marks the first time the leading hospital chain has introduced a music-centered well-being program into a clinical care environment, blending evidence-based mental healthcare with the transformative power of music, according to a Press release.

WTC Mumbai hosts Canadian business delegation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Signalling a renewed push to revive economic engagement between India and Canada, the World Trade Center Mumbai, in association with the All India Association of Industries (AIAI), hosted a Business Roundtable with a Canadian Trade Delegation led by the Indo-Canadian Chamber of Commerce (ICCC) at Centrum Hall.

Andrew Maharaj, Senior Trade Commissioner and Consul, Consulate General of Canada, said India-Canada relations are entering what he described as a “phase of reconstruction and acceleration.” He noted that both countries are now looking to rebuild momentum in economic engagement and aim to scale bilateral trade to nearly \$70 billion by 2030.

Referring to recent discussions between Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney and Prime Minister of India Narendra Modi, Maharaj said the proposed Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) could serve

as an important framework for expanding trade and investment between the two countries.

Highlighting priority sectors, he said Canada is keen to deepen cooperation with India in areas such as energy, artificial intelligence, MSMEs, mining, technical education and innovation-driven industries. He also referred to the \$2.6 billion uranium and nuclear cooperation agreement between the two countries, noting that as India expands its clean energy capacity from 200 GW to 500 GW, collaboration in critical minerals such as lithium and nickel will become increasingly important.

Maharaj added that Canadian investment funds are closely watching India’s growth trajectory, with potential investments estimated to reach \$100 billion by 2030 across infrastructure and strategic sectors. Addressing concerns raised by industry representatives on visa issues, he said Canada is working towards streamlining visa processes to better



Prashant Srivastava, President, Indo-Canadian Chamber of Commerce (ICCC), Dr Vijay Kalantri, Chairman, World Trade Center Mumbai and President, All India Association of Industries and Andrew Maharaj, Senior Trade Commissioner and Consul, Consulate General of Canada

facilitate business travel, industry collaboration and student mobility.

Prashant Srivastava, President, Indo-Canadian Chamber of Commerce (ICCC) said the current trade mission comes at a pivotal moment for rebuilding economic engagement between the two countries after nearly five years of limited interaction. “This mission focuses on emerging sectors such as

artificial intelligence, technology and startups, while also strengthening collaboration in traditional areas including agriculture and agri-food, education and skill development, hospitality and tourism,” he said.

On the sidelines of the roundtable, World Trade Center Mumbai and the Indo-Canadian Chamber of Commerce (ICCC) signed a Memorandum of

Understanding (MoU) aimed at strengthening cooperation in trade facilitation, business delegations, knowledge exchange and industry engagement between India and Canada.

Vijay Kalantri, Chairman, World Trade Center Mumbai and President, All India Association of Industries, said bilateral trade between India and Canada currently stands at around \$13 billion, with sig-

nificant potential for expansion. “As India continues its strong economic momentum and is expected to become the world’s third-largest economy by 2026, new opportunities are emerging in sectors such as energy, education, skilled workforce mobility, technology and tourism,” he said.

Kalantri added that Canada continues to attract Indian businesses and investors, while several Canadian pension funds are exploring investment opportunities in India’s infrastructure and growth sectors.

“Education and talent mobility remain important pillars of bilateral engagement, with more than 700,000 Indian students pursuing higher education in Canada,” he noted. Captain Somesh Batra, Chairman, World Trade Center Mumbai, delivered the Vote of Thanks, expressing appreciation to the Canadian delegation and industry participants for contributing to a constructive dialogue aimed at strengthening economic ties between the two countries.

PM Modi unveils ₹23,552 cr projects for Barak Valley

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Marking a significant milestone for regional development, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, in the presence of Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, unveiled a suite of transformative projects worth ₹23,552 crore for the Barak Valley on Saturday. The initiative, launched at a programme in Silchar, aims to bolster connectivity and strengthen infrastructure across the region.

The Prime Minister performed the Bhumi Pujan for the 167-kilometre Silchar High-Speed Corridor and laid the foundation for the Silchar flyover and the Patharkandi Agricultural College. These projects are designed to boost regional connectivity, alleviate persistent traffic congestion, and enhance agricultural education.

Chief Minister Sarma hailed the day as historic for the valley and the entire State. He highlighted that the new Silchar-Guwahati corridor, spanning from Mawlyngkhung near Umiam in Meghalaya to Panchgram, will reduce the distance between the two cities to 252



kilometres. Crucially, this corridor is expected to reduce travel time from eight and a half hours to approximately five hours.

Addressing the audience, the Chief Minister noted that the project was initiated following the Prime Minister’s recognition of the recurring disruptions on the existing route via Haflong. He remarked that Assam has received unprecedented investment under the current leadership, including the substantial outlay for the Silchar-Guwahati corridor and the proposed tunnel project beneath the Brahmaputra, estimated at ₹20,000 crore.

Further development plans include a corridor con-

necting Srirampur to Guwahati to ensure seamless travel to Silguri within ten hours. Additionally, the State Government has secured environmental clearance for the construction of the Doloo Airport, with work slated to commence imminently.

Sarma emphasised that the Government has addressed the long-standing grievances of Barak Valley residents, ensuring equitable development across the Barak Valley, Brahmaputra Valley, and the hill and plain regions. He also announced that the new ₹565 crore flyover in Silchar, stretching from Trunk Road to Rongirkhari Point, will resolve long-standing traffic issues. Other regional developments include a planned medical college and an ongoing super-specialty block at the Silchar Medical College.

To expedite growth, the Government has established an agricultural college at Patharkandi at a cost of ₹122 crore. With the inauguration of the Assam Secretariat for the Barak Valley, the regional pace of development will be further accelerated. He, therefore, described the present period as a golden era for Assam. During this time, State Government, under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has built a strong foundation for peace, development, and industrial growth in the State.

Union Minister for Ports, Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal, Minister for Barak Valley Development Kaushik Rai, Animal Husbandry and Veterinary Minister Krishnendu Paul, Members of Parliament Parimal Suklabaidya, Kripanath Mallah, and Kanad Purkayastha, along with several legislators and many other distinguished guests, were present on the occasion.

Remaining patient best strategy for investors amid uncertainties: SEBI Chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

SEBI chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey on Saturday urged investors, especially retail ones, to remain patient, terming it the “best strategy” in uncertain times.

In remarks made amid the Middle East conflict-induced selling pressures in the markets, Pandey said past episodes of turbulence in markets like the onset of the Covid-19 pandemic or the Russia-Ukraine conflict have shown that things stabilise eventually.

The Sebi chief said global efforts are underway to restore stability, even as the ongoing tensions in parts of the world have created uncertainty in energy markets.

“For many investors — especially retail investors — the best strategy during such a period of uncertainty is to remain patient,” Pandey said, speaking at an event organised by Money control.

The chief of the Indian capital markets regulator



SEBI Chief Tuhin Kanta Pandey

acknowledged that “uncertainty” dominates the global economic landscape, and added that the same is triggered by technology changes with the adoption of artificial intelligence and geopolitical tensions.

Citing past experience, Pandey said, “Markets experienced turbulence ... but they eventually stabilised.”

He went on to say that uncertainty is not an exception but a recurring feature in financial markets, and added that the real test of a system is to check if it continues to function smoothly, fairly and efficiently in the face of challenges.

“In uncertain times, the strength of a capital market does not lie in the absence of volatility.

India to host global steel leaders at Bharat Steel 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Steel is all prepared to host Bharat Steel 2026, a landmark two-day summit scheduled for 16-17 April in New Delhi, bringing together some of the world’s most influential voices in the steel industry. The gathering will convene over 100 speakers, more than 700 delegates and upwards of 200 exhibitors spanning the entire steel value chain. From mining and raw materials to logistics and downstream manufacturing.

Governments, foreign delegations, technology innova-



tors and investors are all expected to attend, as the capital positions itself at the heart of the global steel supply chain conversation.

The summit arrives at a pivotal moment for India’s steel sector as according to provisional Government

figures, the country’s finished steel exports surged 36.6% year-on-year to 6.02 million metric tonnes in the first 11 months of financial year 2025-26, whilst crude steel production climbed 11.2% over the same period to 153.61 million metric tonnes.

Sandeep Poundrik, Secretary of the Ministry of Steel, described the event as “an important industry gathering to discuss critical aspects of the global steel supply chain including the impact of tariffs, trade policies, technology disruptions, raw material security and logistics infrastructure.”

The speaker line-up reflects the summit’s considerable global ambition with among those confirmed to address the forum are Sajjan Jindal, Chairman and Managing Director of JSW Group; Naveen Jindal, Chairman of Jindal Steel and Member of Parliament; Anil

Agarwal, Non-Executive Chairman of Vedanta Limited; Takahiro Mori, Representative Director and Vice Chairman of Nippon Steel Corporation; and Dr Jennifer Holmgren, Chief Executive of carbon-recycling firm LanzaTech, alongside senior figures from ABB, Danieli, and SMS Group.

With the global steel industry navigating a period of profound transformation shaped by decarbonisation pressures, shifting trade flow and technological disruption — Bharat Steel 2026 looks set to be a forum where consequential decisions begin to take shape.

Bank fraud: CBI questions Anil Ambani’s son

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI questioned Anil Ambani’s son, Jai Anmol Ambani, for nearly five hours for a second consecutive day on Saturday in connection with an alleged ₹228-crore fraud involving the Union Bank of India, officials said.

Jai Anmol Ambani, the former director of Reliance Home Finance Limited (RHFL), was quizzed at the federal agency’s headquarters here in connection with the bank-fraud case, in which he was booked along with RHFL’s former CEO and whole-time director Ravindra Sudhakar, among others, they said.

There was no immediate reaction from the company. The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) conducted searches at Jai Anmol Ambani’s residence on December 9, 2025, after lodging an FIR against him and others.

The CBI had acted on a complaint from the Union Bank of India (previously, the Andhra Bank), alleging that the company did not repay the credit



Jai Anmol Ambani

availed from the bank, which turned the account into a non-performing asset (NPA) in 2019.

The CBI registered a criminal case against RHFL — a Reliance ADA Group company — its promoters and directors and unidentified bank officials on the

basis of the bank’s complaint on allegations of criminal conspiracy, cheating and criminal misconduct, and thereby causing a wrongful loss of ₹228.06 crore to the bank, a CBI spokesperson said on Friday.

“The account of Reliance Home Finance Limited was declared as an NPA on September 30, 2019, and as fraud on October 10, 2024, by the Union Bank of India...,” she said. RHFL had availed loans to the tune of ₹5,572.35 crore from 18 banks, financial institutions, non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) and corporate bodies, including the Union Bank of India, the CBI spokesperson said. “A thorough investigation is being conducted into the allegations of defrauding all the banks/FIs (financial institutions), etc. by the accused company,” the CBI spokesperson said in a statement. She added that the agency had obtained search warrants from a special CBI court in Mumbai and conducted searches at two official premises of RHFL and the residential premises of Jai Anmol Ambani and Sudhakar in Mumbai.

Iran war forces US U-turn on Russian oil: Abbas Araghchi

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai/Athens

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi has said the US, despite "bullying India" to end Russian oil imports, is now begging them to buy crude from Moscow, two weeks after its war with Iran.

"The US spent months on bullying India into ending oil imports from Russia," said Araghchi on Friday in a post on social media platform X.

"After two weeks of war with Iran, White House is now begging the world - including India - to buy Russian crude," he added. This comes after, on March 5, the US issued a 30-day waiver allowing India to buy Russian oil, having previously imposed heavy sanctions related to the war in Ukraine.

Calling out Europe's stance on the conflict in West Asia, the

minister termed the war on Iran "illegal" and said that Europe thought backing an illegal war on Iran would win US support against Russia. He even termed the current stance of the Trump administration towards the purchase of Russian crude oil as "Pathetic".

Starting February 28, the US and Israel launched a joint attack on Iran, which came after days of build-up with US President Donald Trump ramping up the pressure on Tehran to agree to a new deal on its nuclear programme. Iran's retaliation escalated the war to the entire Gulf region.

A Greek-flagged oil tanker was damaged in a suspected drone attack in the Black Sea while approaching the



Fire and plume of smoke rise after debris from an intercepted Iranian drone struck an oil facility in Fujairah, UAE. AP

Russian port of Novorossiysk, authorities said. Greece's shipping ministry said the attack occurred early Saturday, causing material damage, but the 24 crew members were unharmed and the vessel's seaworthiness was not under threat.

The Maran Homer, chartered by US oil giant Chevron, was travelling from Thessaloniki in northern Greece to the Black Sea port and was due to sail on to Istanbul. It was struck by a missile or drone before picking up Kazakh oil, according to Greek Government officials.

Greek Maritime Affairs Minister Vassilis Kikilias said Athens would lodge a "strong complaint" with the country deemed responsible, without giving further details.

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER, PWD (BUILDING)
ASSAM, CHANDMARI, GUWAHATI-3

No. CE/TB-III(B)/08/2026/04

PRESS NOTICE INVITING TENDER

The Chief Engineer, P.W.D., Assam on behalf of the Governor of Assam invites bids through Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) Mode-I of contract for the following works under P.W.D. (Bldg.), Assam from eligible Firm/Contractor of repute having requisite experience in similar nature of work. Details of bid may be seen at e-procurement portal www.assamtenders.gov.in. The bidders must be enrolled in www.assamtenders.gov.in

Sl. No.	Name of Work	Approx value of work	Completion Period	Bid Security 2% of Bid value for and General category, 1% of Bid value for Reserved category	Cost of Bid
1.	Infrastructure Development near Bhootnath Kali Mandir (Phase-II).	Rs. 8,40,37,949.00	18 (Eighteen) Months	For General category, Rs. 16,80,759.00 and For Reserved category Rs.8,40,379.00	Rs.16,100.00

N.B:- 1. Value of work may vary according to the detail NIT.
2. The Press Notice will form a part of the Bidding Document.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer, P.W.D. Bldg, Assam
Chandmari, Guwahati-3

DIPR/C/PIO/1009/15-Mar-26

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER, PWD (BUILDING)
ASSAM, CHANDMARI, GUWAHATI-3

No. CE/TB-III(B)/10/2026/07

PRESS NOTICE INVITING TENDER

The Chief Engineer, P.W.D., Assam on behalf of the Governor of Assam invites bids through Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) Mode-I of contract for the following works under P.W.D. (Bldg.), Assam from eligible Finn/Contractor of repute having requisite experience in similar nature of work. Details of bid may be seen at e-procurement portal www.assamtenders.gov.in. The bidders must be enrolled in www.assamtenders.gov.in

Sl. No.	Name of work	Approx value of work	Completion Period	Bid Security 2 % of Bid value for General category, and 1% of Bid value for Reserved category	Cost of Bid
1.	Proposed (G+2) Residential Building (Bhogjara Block) at Basistha, Kamrup (M), Assam.	Rs. 1,84,03,038.00	12 (Twelve) Months	For General category. Rs. 3,68,061.00 and For Reserved category Rs. 1.84,030.00	Rs. 3,700.00

N.B:- 1. Value of work may vary according to the detail NIT.
2. The Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Document.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer, P.W.D. Bldg, Assam
Chandmari, Guwahati-3

DIPR/C/PIO/1010/15-Mar-26

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER, PWD (BUILDING), ASSAM
CHANDMARI, GUWAHATI-3.

No. CE/TB-II(Bldg.)/109/2024/6

PRESS NOTICE

The Chief Engineer, P.W.D. (Building), Assam, on behalf of the Governor of Assam invites bids for the works detailed in the table below, from contractors having experience in similar nature of work.

Details of the bid may be seen at e-procurement portal website i.e. www.assamtenders.gov.in. The bidders must be enrolled in www.assamtenders.gov.in

Sl. No.	Name of work	Value of Work	Completion Period	Bid Security	Tender Processing Fee
1.	Proposed Judicial Qtr. Grade-II (G+2) for SDJM Court Complex, Titabar, Dist. Jorhat	Rs.3,84,79,149.00	12(Twelve) Months	2% of value of work for General and 1% of value of work for Reserved category	Rs.7696.00

N.B:- (i) Value of work may vary according to the detail NIT.
(ii) he Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Document.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer, PWD (Bldg.), Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3

DIPR/C/PIO/1005/15-Mar-26

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER, PWD (BUILDING), ASSAM CHANDMARI, GUWAHATI-3.

No. CE/TB-II(Bldg.)/26/2025/5

PRESS NOTICE

The Chief Engineer, P.W.D. (Building), Assam, on behalf of the Governor of Assam invites bids for the works detailed in the table below, from contractors having experience in similar nature of work.

Details of the bid may be seen at e-procurement portal website i.e. www.assamtenders.gov.in. The bidders must be enrolled in www.assamtenders.gov.in

Sl. No.	Name of work	Value of Work	Completion Period	Bid Security	Tender Processing Fee
1.	Construction of RCC(G+3) Judicial Officer's (Grade-II) Quarter with Ground Floor Parking Facility at Golaghat	Rs. 4,45,72,522.00	15(Fifteen) Months	2% of value of work for General and 1% of value of work for Reserved category	Rs.8915.00

N.B:-Value of work may vary according to the detail NIT.
The Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Document.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer, PWD (Bldg.), Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3

DIPR/C/PIO/1006/15-Mar-26

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER, PWD (BUILDING), ASSAM , GUWAHATI-3.

No. CE/TB-11(Bldg.)/06/2026/2

PRESS NOTICE

The Chief Engineer, PWD (Building), Assam, on behalf of the Governor of Assam, invites bids from eligible contractors/firms having requisite experience in similar nature of works for the following work. Details of the bid may be seen at e-procurement portal website i.e. www.assamtenders.gov.in. The bidders must be enrolled in www.assamtenders.gov.in

Sl. No.	Name of work	Approx. Value of work (in Rs.)	Bid Security	Cost of Document (in Rs)	Completion period
1.	Construction of District & Session Judge's Quarter, Grade-1 Judicial Officer's Quarter - 2 units, Grade-11 Judicial Officer's Quarter - 4 units, Grade- III Judicial Officer's Quarter - 4 units, at Kajalgaon in Chirang District, BTC. Assam.	15,68,34,885.00	2 % for General category or 1 % for Reserved category on value of work	20,000.00	24 (Twenty Four) Months

N.B:- (i) Value of work may vary according to the detail NIT.
(ii) he Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Document.
(iii) The Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Document.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer, PWD (Bldg.), Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3

DIPR/C/PIO/1004/15-Mar-26

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE DIRECTOR OF FISHERIES, ASSAM
MEEN BHAWAN::GUWAHATI-16::ASSAM

PRESS NOTICE

The Directorate of Fisheries, Assam, Guwahati, invites e-Tenders from the intending contractors / firms/suppliers for execution / supply of "Establishment of Integrated Aqua Park at Village No.1 Dhalpur (in GBKPS), Mouza - Sipajhar under Sipajhar Revenue Circle, Darrang District of Assam under PMMSY 2025-26" required in the Department of, Fisheries with an estimated amount of Rs. **32,96,61,000.00**. An amount of **Rs.65,93,220.00** (in case of bidders belong to **SC/ ST/OBC / MOBC/UGE Rs.32,96,610.00**.) is to be submitted as EMD/Bid Security. The Tender documents can be downloaded from www.assamtenders.gov.in from **16/03/2026 (16:00 hours)**.

● A pre-bid meeting is scheduled on **23/03/2026 at 01:00 PM**. Address for the meeting

Offline Mode:	Online Mode:
The Directorate of Fisheries Meen Bhawan, Assam, Guwahati-16.	https://meet.google.com/hmd-usaa-csw

● The last date of submission of tender document is **06/04/2026 up to 02:00 PM**.
● The bid will be opened online on the e-procurement portal on **06/04/2026 at 02:30 PM**

The TIA reserves the right to accept or reject any bid/tender and to cancel/annul the bidding process and reject all bids at any time prior to contract award.

Sd/-
Director of Fisheries, Assam
Meen Bhawan, Guwahati-16

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE DIRECTOR OF FISHERIES, ASSAM
MEEN BHAWAN::GUWAHATI-16::ASSAM

PRESS NOTICE

The Directorate of Fisheries, Assam, Guwahati, invites e-Tenders from the intending contractors / firms / suppliers for execution / supply of "Establishment of Freshwater Fish Brood Bank at Gerimari Village, Mouza-Rangamati under Mangaldoi Reveneu Circle in Darrang District under PMMSY 2025-26" with an estimated amount of INR **4,76,42,200.00**. An amount of **Rs.9,52,844.00** or **Rs.4,76,422.00** (in case of bidders belong to **SC/ ST/ OBC / MOBC/ UGE**.) is to be submitted as EMD/Bid Security. The Tender documents can be downloaded from www.assamtenders.gov.in from **16/03/2026 (16:00 hours)**.

● A pre-bid meeting is scheduled on **23/03/2026 at 01:00 PM**. Address for the meeting

Offline Mode:	Online Mode:
The Directorate of Fisheries Meen Bhawan, Assam, Guwahati-16.	https://meet.google.com/ted-bwuk-hsu

● The last date of submission of tender document is **06/04/2026 up to 12:30 PM**.
● The bid will be opened online on the e-procurement portal on **06/04/2026 at 02:30 PM**

The TIA reserves the right to accept or reject any bid/tender and to cancel/annul the bidding process and reject all bids at any time prior to contract award.

Sd/-
Director of Fisheries, Assam
Meen Bhawan, Guwahati-16

DIPR/C/PIO/1011/15-Mar-26

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER, PWD (BUILDING), ASSAM
CHANDMARI, GUWAHATI-3.

No. CE/TB-II(Bldg.)/05/2026/3

PRESS NOTICE

The Chief Engineer, P.W.D. (Building), Assam, on behalf of the Governor of Assam invites bids for the works detailed in the table below, from contractors having experience in similar nature of work.

Details of the bid may be seen at e-procurement portal website i.e. www.assamtenders.gov.in. The bidders must be enrolled in www.assamtenders.gov.in

Sl. No.	Name of Work	Value of Work	Completion Period	Bid Security	Tender Processing Fee
1.	Construction of Quarter(RCC Building G+4) for Judicial Officers at O/o the District and Session Judge, Nalbari	Rs. 7,04,86,558.00	18 (Eighteen) Months	2% of value of work for General and 1% of value of work for Reserved category	Rs. 14100.00

N.B:-Value of work may vary according to the detail NIT.
The Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Document.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer, PWD (Bldg.), Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3

DIPR/C/PIO/1008/15-Mar-26

Committed to safety of each diaspora member: Nepal minister

SHIRISH B PRADHAN
Kathmandu

The Government is serious and cautious about the Nepali nationals in West Asian countries amid the conflict situation and operating rescue flights for many of them, Minister for Foreign Affairs Balananda Sharma said on Saturday.

There are around 3 million Nepalese presumed to be residing in different countries in the Gulf region, the Government said two days ago and added, Nepal is actively engaged in carrying out rescue operations for more than 5,000 of its citizens from the region.

On Saturday, while speaking at the 12th Annual General Meeting of the Non-Resident Nepalese Association (NRNA) here, Sharma said the Government is committed to the safety of each and every Nepali. The US and Israel have launched a massive joint attack on Iran since February 28.

With Iran's retaliation, the war has extended to the entire Gulf region. The Nepal Government accords top



Minister Balananda Sharma

priority to the safety and welfare of the Nepalese national residing in the conflict-hit region, Sharma said, adding, an Emergency Control Room has been brought into operation to coordinate efforts regarding the safety and evacuation of the Nepalese nationals sheltered in the conflict hit-zone.

The minister also informed that rescue flights have been operated through the coordination of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs as well as the Nepali missions in the respective countries to assist the Nepali nationals in case of emergencies.

US seeks to close \$1.6 trillion revenue gap with raft of new tariffs



ASSOCIATED PRESS
Washington

The Trump administration this week stepped up its ambitious effort to replace about \$1.6 trillion in lost tariff revenue that was eliminated by the Supreme Court's decision to strike down a range of the president's import taxes.

Recovering that lost revenue, which the White House was counting on to help offset the steep, multi-trillion dollar cost of its tax cuts, is possible but will be challenging, experts say. The administration has to use different legal provisions to impose new duties, and those provisions require longer, complex processes that US companies can use to seek exemptions. It could be months or more before it is clear how much revenue the replacement tariffs will yield.

"I wouldn't bet against this administration being able to get back on paper the same effective tariff rate they had before," said Elena Patel, co-director of the Urban-Brookings Tax Policy Center. But the new approach will "make it easier for people to contest the tariffs, which is going to put a big asterisk on the revenue until all that is settled."

On Wednesday, US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer said the administration will investigate 16 economies — including the European Union — over whether their governments are subsidizing excessive factory capacity in a way that disadvantages US manufacturing. The investigation will also cover China, South Korea, and Japan, Greer said.

In addition, he said there would be a second investigation of dozens of countries to see if their failure to ban goods made by forced labor amounts to an unfair trade practice that harms the United States.

That investigation will also cover the EU and China, as well as Mexico, Canada, Australia, and Brazil. Both investigations are being conducted under Section 301 of the 1974 Trade Act, which requires the administration to consult with the targeted countries, as well as hold public hearings and allow affected US industries to comment.

A hearing as part of the factory capacity investigation will be held May 5, while a hearing on the forced labor investigation will occur April 28. It's a far cry from the emergency law that President Donald Trump relied on in his first year in office, which allowed him to immediately impose tariffs on any country, at nearly any level, simply by issuing an executive order.

Moments after the Supreme Court's ruling, Trump imposed a 10 per cent tariff on all imports under a separate legal authority, but that duty can only last for 150 days.

Russian strike on the Kyiv region kills 4

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Kyiv

A combined missile and drone attack on the Kyiv region killed at least four people and wounded at least 15 overnight into on Saturday, according to the head of the regional administration for the Ukrainian Capital.

Three of the wounded were in critical condition, of whom two were undergoing surgery, Mykola Kalashnyk reported on Saturday.

The attack hit four districts, damaging residential buildings, educational institutions, enterprises and critical infrastructure, Kalashnyk added in a social media post.

The strikes came days after the US postponed peace



Firefighters approaching damaged railway workshops following a Russia missile attack in Brovary

talks between Russia and Ukraine scheduled for this week, citing the war in the Middle East. As US and Israeli missiles and bombs rain on

Iran, Russia has responded with words of indignation but no action to support its ally. Moscow's failure to help another ally, after the 2024

ouster of former Syrian ruler Bashar Assad and January's U.S. arrest of Venezuelan leader Nicolas Maduro, highlighted the limits of its influ-

ence — but the Kremlin expects to reap benefits from the Iran war. Russia is already profiting from a surge in global energy prices, and could hope that the Mideast war will detract attention from Ukraine and deplete Western arsenals.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Friday that the 30-day U.S. waiver on Russian oil sanctions amid the Iran war is “not the right decision” and won’t help bring a stop to Russia’s more than 4-year-old invasion of Ukraine.

“This easing alone by the United States could provide Russia with about \$10 billion for the war,” Zelenskyy said. “This certainly does not help peace.”

11 Indian nationals charged in US over visa fraud



YOSHITA SINGH
■ New York

Eleven Indian nationals, living illegally in the US, have been charged with visa fraud for conspiring to carry out staged armed robberies of convenience shops, according to US federal prosecutors.

Authorities said the suspects are accused of organising fake robberies for the purpose of allowing the store clerks to falsely claim they were crime victims on immigration applications towards getting a Green Card.

They have been charged with one count of conspiracy to commit visa fraud.

They all were living unlawfully in various US states such as Massachusetts, Kentucky and Ohio. Dipikaben was deported to India after unlawfully residing in Weymouth, Massachusetts, the Justice Department said in a statement.

Massachusetts and released following an initial appearance in federal court in Boston . (PTI)

Kazakhstan set to hold constitutional referendum



ASHOKE RAJ ■
Astana

Kazakhstan is fully prepared to conduct a historic nationwide referendum on a new draft Constitution this Sunday, said Arman Issetov, Deputy Minister of Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Kazakhstan.

In an interaction with The Pioneer, Kazakhstan's Deputy Foreign Minister said the country is ready to hold what he called a “historic referendum” for a better Kazakhstan,” emphasising that the process reflects the Government’s commitment to reform and democratic participation.

“We are fully prepared to conduct the referendum on Sunday. This is a historic moment for our country and an important step toward building a better and more just Kazakhstan,” the deputy minister said. He described the voting as a decisive step toward building a stronger and more inclusive state.

The referendum, scheduled for March 15, will allow citizens across the country to vote on a comprehensive set of constitutional reforms designed to modernize Kazakhstan’s political system and strengthen the protection of citizens’ rights and freedoms.

According to the official, the reforms aim to establish a more balanced governance model with stronger institutions, greater public participation in decision-making, and enhanced accountability across all branches of Government. The proposed constitutional changes are part of a broader reform agenda initiated by President Kassym-Jomart Tokayev, aimed at building what authorities describe as a “just Kazakhstan.”

“These reforms are about strengthening statehood, protecting citizens’ rights

and ensuring that the State serves the interests of the people,” the deputy minister said.

He noted that the drafting process included extensive public consultation. Over the past several months, thousands of proposals were submitted by citizens through Government platforms, reflecting widespread civic engagement in shaping the country’s future constitutional framework.

The new draft Constitution contains significant structural and conceptual changes, with amendments affecting a large portion of the existing constitutional text. The reforms place particular emphasis on human rights protections, social justice, and the rule of law.

MFA Officials say the new constitutional model will promote stronger democratic institutions, including a more effective Parliament, an independent judiciary and improved mechanisms for dialogue between the Government and society.

The referendum has also drawn significant international attention. Hundreds of international observers and foreign journalists have been accredited to monitor the vote, reflecting global interest in Kazakhstan’s political reforms.

Authorities say preparations for the referendum have been completed across the country, with polling stations ready to open on Sunday to allow citizens to cast their votes.

The deputy foreign minister expressed confidence that the referendum will mark a turning point in Kazakhstan’s political development. “This referendum is about the future of our country. We believe it will lay the foundation for a stronger, fairer and more prosperous Kazakhstan,” he said.

PAK POLICE KILL 6 TERRORISTS IN KHYBER PAKHTUNKHWA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Peshawar

The Counter-Terrorism Department of Pakistan police gunned down six terrorists during an intelligence-based operation in the restive northwestern Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province.

A spokesman for the counter terrorism department (CTD)said the operation was conducted in the Shagai area of Lakki Marwat district. The terrorists opened fire on the



CTD team as they approached their location, following which the law enforcers fired in retaliation, he said. The firing continued for an hour and ended with the killing of six terrorists, he added.

The process of identifying the slain terrorists was underway, following which action would be taken against their facilitators and associates, the spokesman said. Four Kalashnikovs with magazines and ammunition, two 9mm pistols, eight hand grenades and an improvised explosive device was found in the possession of the terrorists.

White House wants to build underground centre to provide security screening for visitors

DARLENE SUPERVILLE
■ Washington

The White House wants to build an underground centre to provide security screening for visitors, the latest step in the Trump administration’s plan to overhaul the grounds.

Plans, including renderings of the 33,000-square-foot (3,066-square-metre) centre, were included in the preliminary agenda released for the April meeting of a federal commission that approves construction on federal land in Washington.

The screening facility



would be built beneath Sherman Park, which is located southeast of the White House and directly south of the Treasury building. The park had for a

long time been the place where White House tourists and guests lined up for security checks before they cleared a series of trailer-type struc-

tures and walked to the East Wing entrance. President Donald Trump tore down the East Wing last fall to build a ballroom. Visitors currently line up near Lafayette Park, across Pennsylvania Avenue from the White House.

The new screening facility would have seven lanes to ease processing and reduce wait times. Construction could begin as early as August, according to the plans, as the White House said it wants the facility operating by July 2028, six months before Trump’s term ends. (AP)

North Korea fires 10 missiles at Sea, says Seoul

KIM TONG-HYUNG
■ Seoul

North Korea on Saturday fired about 10 ballistic missiles toward the eastern sea, South Korea’s military said, staging its own show of force as the rival South conducts a joint military exercise with the United States.

South Korea’s Joint Chiefs of Staff said the missiles were fired from an area near the North Korean capital of Pyongyang, but didn’t immediately say how far they flew. Japan’s Defense Ministry said the weapons landed in waters outside the country’s exclusive economic zone.

The South’s Joint Chiefs said the military has stepped

up surveillance and is maintaining readiness against possible additional launches while closely sharing information with the US and Japan The launches came as the US and South Korean militaries conduct their annual springtime exercises involving thousands of troops while the Trump administration also wages an escalating war in the Middle East.

The war has raised concerns about potential security lapses in South Korea, as local media - citing security camera footage and other images - have speculated that the US is relocating some missile defense assets stationed in the country to support operations against



US Army soldiers participate on the Imjin River in a joint river-crossing exercise between South Korea and the United States in Yeoncheon AP

Iran. When asked by The Associated Press this week whether US Forces Korea was moving interceptor missiles from its Terminal High Altitude Area Defense, or THAAD, system in Seongju to

the Middle East, President Lee Jae Myung’s office said it could not confirm details about US military operations. The office said the potential relocation of US military assets would

not affect the allies’ defense posture against nuclear-armed North Korea, while also citing South Korea’s conventional military strength.

It earlier gave a similar response to reports about the possible relocation of Patriot missile defense systems from South Korea.

North Korea has long described the allies’ drills as invasion rehearsals and often uses them as a pretext to dial up its own military demonstrations or weapons testing. The North in previous years has conducted numerous salvo launches of missiles or artillery while describing them as simulations of nuclear attacks against targets in South Korea. (AP)

Thailand’s death Fest’ invites visitors to embrace mortality

JINTAMAS SAKSORNCHAI
■ Nonthaburi

Thailand’s “Death Fest” invites people to confront mortality while also offering practical services and spiritual advice for the inevitable.

The unusual fair, now in its second year, has broached the subject that’s uncomfortable for many. It’s also one of the central teachings of Buddhism, which shapes much of Thailand’s culture, about life’s unavoidable sufferings: birth, old age, sickness and death.

Sangduan Ngamvinijaroon attended the three-day event Friday with her mother in Nonthaburi province near Bangkok.

She said death used to be



A visitor tries out a coffin at Death Fest in Nonthaburi, Thailand AP

a difficult subject for her family, but having spent more than 20 years caring for ill family members, including her husband with a stroke and relatives with cancer, she has witnessed several

deaths firsthand and now feels more at ease talking about it.

She said she liked the fair because “it’s not just about dying well. It’s also about the present moment and taking

good care of our lives while we’re still here.”

The event brought together experts and organisations involved in health care, financial planning, palliative care, funeral services and memorial innovations. Activities and talks focused not only on preparing for death but also on maintaining quality of life until the final days.

“Death involves everybody. It’s not just about you,” said Zcongklod Bangyikhan, editor-in-chief of The Cloud magazine and one of the event’s lead organisers.

“Instead of wondering what dying will be like, maybe we should think about how to make things easier for the people who remain after we’re gone.” (AP)

US judge pauses termination of deportation protections for some Somali immigrants

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Boston

A US court ruling in Massachusetts temporarily paused the looming termination of Temporary Protected Status for immigrants from Somalia.

US District Judge Allison D Burroughs’ ruling said there would be “weighty” consequences if Somalia’s TPS designation is allowed to expire on Tuesday.

Advocates filed an emergency motion in federal court seeking to pause the termination after the Trump administration promised to end the designation last month



A group of undocumented migrants is deported by US Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents in Texas

during an immigration crackdown in Minneapolis, where many Somalis live. “Over one thousand people will face a myriad of grave risks,” including detention and deportation, physical violence if

removed to Somalia, and forced separation from family members,” the ruling said. Burroughs said implementing an administrative stay and deferring ruling on the postponement gives both sides

time to file briefs on the emergency motion.

“While the stay is in effect, the termination shall be null, void, and of no legal effect,” the ruling said, noting that those with TPS status or pending applications will retain rights including eligibility for work authorisation and protection against deportation and detention.

In a statement, the US Department of Homeland Security said the ruling by a judge appointed by former President Barack Obama is the latest example of preventing Trump from “restoring integrity” to the US immigration system.

Cuban president confirms US talks as island’s energy, economic crises intensify

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Havana

Cuba has held talks with the US Government, Cuban President Miguel Diaz-Canel said, marking the first time the Caribbean country has confirmed widespread speculation about discussions with the Trump administration as it grapples with a severe energy crisis.

Diaz-Canel said the talks “were aimed at finding solutions through dialogue to the bilateral differences between our two nations.”

International factors facilitated these exchanges.” He did not elaborate on those factors, or provide any specifics about the talks, which US President Donald

Trump has alluded to in the past. Cuba’s relations with the US have been fraught for decades and punctuated by animosity, with the exception of a brief rapprochement during former President Barack Obama’s second term.

Asked for comment on Friday, the White House pointed to Trump’s public comments about discussions with Cuba that he said were being led by US Secretary of State Marco Rubio and intended to press major changes in Cuban policies and governance.

Trump has suggested that top Cuban leaders would be smart to avoid the fate of former Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro, who was ousted and arrested in a US

military operation in January. Shortly after Diaz-Canel spoke, two US officials said that Rubio, the son of Cuban immigrants and a longtime Cuba hawk, and top aides met at the end of February in the Caribbean with the grandson of retired Cuban leader Raul Castro, who is believed to play an influential role in the Government despite not holding an official post.

The officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity because of the sensitivity of the discussions, said that Rubio had met secretly with Raul Guillermo Rodriguez Castro on the sidelines of a Caribbean Community leaders meeting in St. Kitts and Nevis on February 25. At



Cuban President Miguel Diaz-Canel

the time, Rubio refused to say who, if anyone, he was speaking with in or close to the Cuban Government.

Diaz-Canel said that the purpose of the talks with the US was to identify “bilateral

problems that require solutions based on their severity and impact” and find solutions to them.

He said that the aim was “to determine the willingness of both parties to take

concrete actions for the benefit of the people of both countries. And in addition, to identify areas of cooperation to confront threats and guarantee the security and peace of both nations, as well as in the region.”

Diaz-Canel said that no petroleum shipments have arrived in Cuba in the past three months, which he blamed on a US energy blockade. He said the island is running on natural gas, solar power and thermoelectric plants, and that the depletion of fuel oil and diesel forced two power plants to shut down and has limited the generation of power at solar parks.

The most recent blackout was blamed on a broken

boiler at a thermoelectric plant that forced the shutdown of Cuba’s power grid.

The president said that Cuba, which produces 40 per cent of its petroleum, has been generating its own power, but that it hasn’t been sufficient to meet demand. The lack of power has affected communications, education and transportation, and the Government has had to postpone surgeries for tens of thousands of people as a result, he said, adding: “The impact is tremendous.”

“Even with everything we’re putting together, we still need oil,” he said, adding that production output also has dropped. “Without energy, no country can

produce at normal levels. All of this has meant making adjustments to employment.” Last month, Cuba implemented austere fuel-saving measures and has converted more than 115 bakeries to run on firewood or coal.

“Cubans are desperate,” said Elvis Hernandez, 62. “You can’t live without water or electricity. That’s why we want a consensus to be reached. If there are talks, let them be productive. Let them achieve something good through those conversations.” “If all of this leads to agreements and solutions that will improve our lives, then all the better, because the situation is quite difficult right now,” he said.

BRIEFLY

Mexico hit by another injury blow as Marcel Ruiz tears ACL



In the span of three days, Mexico has lost two players for the World Cup. Midfielder Marcel Ruiz tore the anterior cruciate ligament in his right knee, his club Toluca announced on Friday. The 25-year-old Ruiz injured the joint on Wednesday in a CONCACAF Champions Cup match against San Diego of the MLS. Toluca said in a statement that in addition to the ligament rupture, Ruiz also suffered a meniscus tear in the same joint and will undergo surgery. "Everyone at this club regrets what happened and we stand in solidarity with him, wishing him a speedy recovery," the team said. Mexico plays the World Cup opener on June 11 against South Africa. Ruiz was key in helping Toluca win their second consecutive championship last December. Ruiz received his first call-up to the senior national team in 2023, and has been one of the most consistent players since Javier Aguirre took over as manager in August 2024. The midfielder has 17 matches with the national team and was expected to go to his first World Cup. His absence adds to Club America goalkeeper Luis Malagon, who was diagnosed on Wednesday with a ruptured Achilles tendon in his left leg. Mexico has another half-dozen players sidelined, although the most serious case is that of right back Rodrigo Huescas, who tore a knee ligament last November.

Marseille win over Ligue 1 struggler Auxerre



Substitute Amine Gouiri scored with 11 minutes remaining to give Marseille a 1-0 win over Ligue 1 struggler Auxerre. The result left Marseille in third place, three points clear of Lyon, which plays at Le Havre on Sunday. Marseille was seven points behind second-placed Lens and eight adrift of league leader Paris Saint-Germain. Although the south coast club has been a constant presence among the clubs pushing for a European place next season its form has been inconsistent since the start of the year. However, Gouiri's return has added goals to the mix. The Algeria international missed nine games after a shoulder injury in October but has scored five times since returning to the side in early January. Here he replaced English defender CJ Egan-Riley after 62 minutes and proved decisive. Auxerre remained third to last with just one win in its last 11 games. It was five points from safety.

WADA to weigh barring Trump, US officials from LA Olympics

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Washington

The World Anti-Doping Agency is considering rewriting its rules to try barring President Donald Trump and all US government officials from attending the LA Olympics in 2028 in a move that could also have implications for the World Cup being hosted by the US this summer. The proposal, on the agenda for next Tuesday's meeting of the global drug-fighting watchdog's executive committee, is the latest maneuver to come out of a yearslong refusal of the US government to pay its annual dues to WADA. The refusal is part of the American govern-



ment's unanimous, bipartisan protest of the agency's handling of a case involving Chinese swimmers and other issues. The Associated Press learned of the agenda item through correspondence it obtained between WADA and European officials involved in the agency's decision-making. Two others

Mayank becomes first GM from North-East region

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

Talented youngster Mayank Chakraborty crossed the final hurdle in his promising career by securing his third and final GM norm, becoming the 94th Grandmaster and the first from India's North-East region to achieve the coveted title. Hailing from Guwahati in Assam, the 17-year-old Chakraborty — who became an International Master in 2024 — achieved the feat with a round to spare in the eighth round of the Hotel Stockholm North by First Hotels Chess Talents Tournament, defeating Swedish IM Philip Lindgren. Chakraborty was at the



top of his game in the victory over Lindgren, accumulating the required 6.5 points that were enough to secure his

final Grandmaster norm. In the final round, he played out an exciting draw with English International Master Jonah B

Willow to seal what was his most memorable performance to date. Chakraborty also crossed the critical 2500

Indian campaign ends at Swiss Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Basel

India's Tharun Manneppalli put up a gallant fight before going down to Indonesia's Anthony Sinisuka Ginting in a thrilling three-game quarterfinal at the Swiss Open Super 300 badminton tournament here. The world No. 43 Indian lost 19-21, 21-19, 13-21 to Ginting, who is returning from injuries that marred his 2025 season, including a significant back problem. The defeat also brought the curtains down on India's campaign at the USD 250,000 tournament. Ginting opened up a 6-2 lead early, and though Manneppalli clawed back to



level at 11-11, the Indonesian pulled away to 16-12 before earning four game points. The Indian saved three before conceding the opening game. In the second game, Manneppalli broke away from 6-6 to surge to 11-7 and then 19-13. Ginting suddenly came alive, reeling off six points to draw level at 19-19, but the Indian held his nerve to take the match into the decider.

KKR took wrong decision to let Shreyas Iyer and Phil Salt leave, says Anil Kumble

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Mumbai

Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR) "took the wrong decision" by letting Shreyas Iyer and Phil Salt leave after their title-winning campaign in 2024, and unless the three-time IPL champions understand the importance of retaining key players, they cannot be considered serious title contenders, cautioned the legendary Anil Kumble. Iyer exited KKR to join Punjab Kings, whom he led to their first appearance in the IPL final in nearly a decade in the last edition, while Phil Salt — another



vital cog in KKR's success in 2024 — moved to Royal Challengers Bengaluru, where he played an impactful role in the franchise's maiden title win last year. "Two years ago, KKR won the IPL and lifted their third trophy. Two important cogs

in that wheel were Shreyas Iyer and Phil Salt. Both played crucial roles in helping them win but KKR let both of them go," Kumble noted in a JioHotstar release. "There is no consistency from them in terms of player retention. KKR took the wrong decision by letting Shreyas Iyer and Phil Salt leave (and) that has left them without an IPL-winning captain." Kumble noted that even though KKR have an experienced campaigner in Ajinkya Rahane as their skipper, he has not yet won the IPL as a captain. "Yes, Ajinkya Rahane is an experienced campaigner. He has

led Mumbai in domestic cricket and Rajasthan Royals in the IPL. But he has not lifted the IPL title as (a) captain (yet)," Kumble said. "Having a skipper who has won the trophy gives you an advantage. KKR let go of that advantage. They need to learn how to keep hold of their key players. Otherwise, they will keep struggling and cannot be considered favourites to win the trophy," the legendary spinner added. The former India captain heaped praise on Iyer's leadership qualities for guiding Punjab Kings into the IPL final last year.

Rory overcomes back spasms to secure two more days at The Player



ASSOCIATED PRESS
Ponte Vedra Beach

Rory McIlroy wasn't entirely sure he would be able to play in The Players Championship because of muscle spasms in his lower back that forced him to withdraw last Saturday at Bay Hill. Now he's thankful to be playing two more days at the TPC Sawgrass. But it took a lot more work than he wanted Friday. McIlroy, the defending champion and two-time winner of The Players, was over the projected cut line approaching his final hole at the par-5 ninth. He blistered a 310-yard drive, reached the green in two and had a two-putt birdie for a 71.

Satisfaction came only from making the cut. "I'm happy to be here for the weekend. I'm happy to get two more runs at it," McIlroy said. "It would have sucked to be going home this afternoon. So to hang around and hopefully play two more days, that's a win." But it was only his third

birdie of the round in scorable conditions — and only fourth birdie of the tournament — so this wasn't simply about making the cut. McIlroy woke up feeling good about his back. He just couldn't get his putter to wake up. Still, it was a clutch finish to sit at 1-over 145. "I wish I was further up the leaderboard. I felt like I played well enough today to be up the leaderboard, I just couldn't get a putt to drop," he said. The back no longer appears to be an issue. McIlroy was hopeful it would be like 2023 at the Tour Championship when he had a balky back. It was fine by the weekend, and this appears to be a similar situation. "It feels pretty much there," McIlroy said. "Not all the way there, but I feel like it's just progressively getting better each and every day." McIlroy was not sure what his schedule would be leading to the Masters. He contemplated adding a tournament if he only got in two days at The Players.

Curb Hesson's absolute say in picking teams: Pak's selectors

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Lahore

Pakistan's national selectors are not happy with the absolute authority given to the white-ball head coach Mike Hesson in the selection of players. Selectors Aaqib Javed, Misbah ul Haq, Sarfaraz Ahmed and Asad Shafiq have addressed a media conference in Lahore on Saturday and made it clear they had asked the Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) to review the selection structure for the national side after the team returns home from Bangladesh. "Once the team returns home we will sit down and discuss things with the coaches and captain and



find a suitable selection system for the national team," Aaqib, the senior selector, said. Aaqib, who is also director at the High Performance Centre, admitted that until

Hesson took charge in May last year, the selectors used to be involved even in the selection of playing XI for away and home series. He dismissed a query that perhaps Hesson had been pressurised to

include and play Babar Azam and few other players during the recent T20 World Cup. "The selectors give and gave a list of 21 players to the head coach and captain and they shortlisted 15 players and decide on the playing XI for each match," he said. Since Pakistan were knocked out of the T20 World Cup in the Super 8 stage, the media here has reported about tension between the selectors and Hesson and senior selector, Aleem Dar, also resigned soon after the tournament. Though he didn't give any statement but media reports said he was unhappy at the absolute say Hesson had been given in selection of Pakistan players. Aaqib said in the recent

past the selectors used to be involved in even picking the playing XI after shortlisting 15 or 16 players for any series or tournament. "The system changed in recent times but after the team returns home we will reviewing it," he added. He said the selectors believed that the captain was the most important person followed by the head coach and they should be supported and have authority but at the same time they must be able to discuss and explain to the selectors their future plans. Aaqib, who has been involved with the PCB in different capacities and also worked as interim head coach for some months in 2024/25, also tried to defend the team's recent performances.

LA Liga: Villarreal late show breaks Alaves hearts in exciting draw

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Vitoria-Gasteiz (Spain)

Villarreal equalised 1-1 deep in stoppage time and broke the hearts of relegation-threatened Alaves in La Liga. The home side seemed destined for a first win in six games and a debut three points for coach Quique Sanchez Flores, who was taking charge at home for the first time since replacing Eduardo Coudet nine days ago. Alaves had gone ahead in the 40th minute courtesy of an own goal from center back Rafa Marin. Toni Martinez's clever backheel from the byline smacked off Marin's head



just four meters from goal and flew past his own goalkeeper. However, a late equaliser was always a worry for a side that has conceded as many league goals in the last quarter of an hour as they have in the first half of

their matches this season. Sure enough, Nicolas Pepe did the damage with almost the last kick of the game in the seventh minute of added time when he finished off a counterattack by bending a fine shot into the far corner.

Indian women lose to England, qualify for WC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

The Indian women's hockey team lost 0-2 against the higher-ranked England to finish runners-up in the FIH Hockey World Cup Qualifiers but still managed to qualify for this year's mega-event, here on Saturday.

World number 6 England scored through a penalty corner conversion by Grace Baldson in the 13th minute before doubling their lead through a field strike from Elizabeth Neal in the 43rd minute.

The Indians, ranked ninth in the world, tried their heart and soul throughout the entire 60 minutes but failed

to break the resolute English defence.

Besides champions England, runner-up India and Scotland, who defeated Italy 1-0, qualified from this event for the World Cup.

This edition of the World Cup will be jointly hosted by the Netherlands and Belgium from August 14 to 30 along side the men's tournament.

India began the game on the front foot with Navneet Kaur helping her side earn a penalty corner within the opening two minutes.

However, her drag-flick from the resulting set piece was kept out by the England goalkeeper.

The hosts showed great discipline, maintaining a



solid defensive shape while also making inroads on the end of the field.

However, England grew into the game towards the end of the first quarter, earning a penalty corner

with two minutes to go.

Baldson made the most of that opportunity, finding the back of the net with her drag-flick and scoring her fifth goal from a penalty corner in this tournament

to give England the lead.

The second quarter began in a similar manner, with both the teams not giving much away in this engaging contest.

With eight circle penetrations in the first half, India were asking questions to the England defence but didn't really test the rival goalkeeper, allowing the visitors to hold onto their one-goal advantage at half time.

With the lead, England controlled the tempo of the game by neatly working the ball and maintaining possession.

India had a few opportunities to pile on the pressure, but the visitors stood firm at the back. England eventual-

ly doubled their lead courtesy Neal (43rd). The midfielder was fortunate as her effort deflected off an Indian defender before finding its way past Bichu Devi, giving the visitors a 2-0 lead at the end of the third quarter.

India continued to push forward in search of goals that would get them back into the game.

With the scoreline in their favour, England remained positive in their approach and ensured they don't go into a shell to give the hosts an opportunity.

It was a free-flowing final quarter as India earned a penalty corner in the dying minutes, but they couldn't find the back of the net.

PCB to take legal action against Muzarabani

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lahore

The PCB is set to take legal action against Zimbabwe fast bowler Blessing Muzarabani for signing a contract with IPL team Kolkata Knight Riders, while pulling out of his deal with Islamabad United in the Pakistan Super League.

A reliable source in the board said on Saturday that the legal department had been instructed to file a case against the Zimbabwean, who has now inked a contract with the Knight Riders, replacing Bangladesh pacer Mustafizur Rahman, who was dropped by the franchise as per BCCI's directions. "Since



the IPL and PSL are now clashing after being held in the same window since last year we want to give a clear message to players that once they commit to playing in the PSL, they can't just go and breach their contract and sign a new one with any franchise in the IPL," he said.

No player has been fined for T20 World Cup exit: PCB

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lahore

The Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) on Saturday denied the imposition of fines on members of its T20 World Cup squad for not reaching the semifinals of the tournament.

Amir Mir, the PCB spokesperson, refuted the reports to that effect that appeared in a section of the media. "No player has been fined, but yes, the board is thinking about working out a formula for players because they get a lot of incentives when they perform well," Mir told reporters here.

Mir noted that each player



now earns close to PKR 6-7 crores, so the board is contemplating making them responsible for their performances. "But nothing is final and no player has been fined," he added.

It has been reported that each Pakistani player was

fined PKR five million after the team's exit from the ICC showpiece without reaching the last four stage.

Pakistan cricketers are given central contracts with monthly retainers besides the usual match and tour fees and bonuses for winning matches in different categories. The players also get a share of the logo sponsorship deal signed by the board.

Last year. It was also agreed that the players would get a 3 per cent share of the annual revenues that the PCB gets from the International Cricket Council, which amounts to close to USD 34 million a year.

Kimi Antonelli on pole for Formula 1 Chinese Grand Prix

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Shanghai

Kimi Antonelli stepped up on Saturday when his Mercedes teammate George Russell hit trouble in qualifying to become the youngest-ever driver on pole position for a Formula 1 Grand Prix.

After holding off a challenge from Ferrari to win the sprint race earlier in the day, Russell seemed near-unbeatable. Then he stopped on track in qualifying and limped back to the pits with technical problems.

Russell's team got the car going again with seconds to spare for him to set a time. It was only good enough for second on the grid, 0.222 of a second off Antonelli, who kept up Mercedes' run of



qualifying dominance after F1's sweeping changes to the cars for 2026.

The Ferraris of Lewis Hamilton and Charles Leclerc will start third and fourth. Their fast starts could threaten Mercedes off the line, as they did last week in Australia and in Saturday's

sprint race. The 19-year-old Antonelli becomes the youngest driver to take pole position for a full Grand Prix race, though he was also on pole aged 18 for a sprint race last year in Miami. "It's just the beginning, so obviously there's a lot more to come," Antonelli said. "Really looking

forward to tomorrow. Car is feeling really good, car is strong, so a lot to play for tomorrow. But just super happy with today." Russell said a damaged front wing and gear-change issues made for a "crazy" qualifying session. "As soon as I went out on the track, I could tell something wasn't right," he said. He then had to set a last-chance time with a depleted battery and cold tires.

Russell holds off Ferraris in sprint: Russell won the first race of the season in Australia last weekend, and he followed up taking the 19-lap sprint in China. As last week in Australia, the Ferraris were fast off the line and Russell and Lewis Hamilton swapped the lead several times on the first

few laps. But Russell began to pull away after the early laps with Hamilton fading as the constant battles took a toll on his tires.

Charles Leclerc was second with his teammate Hamilton third.

"Lewis did an amazing job in the in the early laps," Russell said. "He caught me off guard - 20 years of experience. So I've still got a bit to learn." "It was pretty fun in the end," Russell added. "A lot of strategy in play and overtakes. It's not easy. I hope it was fun race to watch. Usually the sprint races are pretty boring."

Hamilton received loud applause from the Shanghai crowd when he began his on-track interview by saying "Ni hao" — hello in Chinese.

Saina Nehwal cautions BWF against major scoring overhaul

AMIT KUMAR DAS
■ New Delhi

Olympic medallist Saina Nehwal has urged the Badminton World Federation (BWF) to exercise caution regarding proposed scoring changes, maintaining that the current 21-point system preserves the sport's essential intensity and endurance.

The game's governing body (BWF) has proposed switching to a 3x15 scoring format from the current 3x21 system, with a membership vote on the change scheduled at the BWF Annual General Meeting in Horsens, Denmark, on April 25.

"Badminton has a rich tradition, and tournaments like the All England Open Badminton Championships and the BWF World



Championships have always been special because of their intensity and endurance factor," Saina, who joined the advisory board of India's International Movement to Unite Nations (IIMUN), said in an interview.

"Any change in scoring or format should be carefully considered. The current 21-

point system has worked well and players have adapted to it over many years. "If changes are introduced, they should ensure that the quality of rallies and the competitive balance of the sport are not affected. At the end of the day, the focus should remain on fair competition and the spirit of the game." According to the

revamped BWF World Tour, the five Super 1000 tournaments, to be staged across Asia and Europe, will introduce a new format in singles, with 48 players competing in a group stage followed by knockouts.

Doubles events will feature 32-pair knockout draws, and each Super 1000 tournament will run for 11 days across two weekends. Saina feels the BWF needs to prioritise player welfare, saying the packed international calendar leaves little room for recovery and can lead to injuries and burnout among elite shuttlers. "Badminton is always a very tough sport both physically and mentally. The rallies are longer, the speed of the game is higher, and players are competing in tourna-

ments almost every week.

"The Badminton World Federation has tried to structure the calendar, but from a player's perspective, recovery time is extremely important. Injuries and fatigue can affect performance and also shorten careers. "I feel the schedule should allow better recovery periods between major tournaments, and teams should have more support for sports science and rehabilitation."

Lakshya has ability and mindset, All England title is not far away: Last week, Lakshya Sen finished runner-up at the All England Open after going down to Chinese Taipei's Lin Chun-Yi in the men's singles final, repeating his near-miss at the tournament after finishing second in 2022. (PTI)

Women's Asian Cup: China beats Taiwan to advance to semifinals

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Perth

Defending champions China defeated Taiwan 2-0 in the Women's Asian Cup quarter-finals on Saturday to book a semifinal against host Australia and a place at the 2027 World Cup.

After 90 minutes ended goalless in a match involving countries with geopolitical tensions, Shao Ziqin finally broke the deadlock three minutes into extra time before a late own goal sealed a deserved win for the dominant Chinese team.

On Friday, Sam Kerr scored one goal and created another as Australia advanced and secured a



World Cup spot with a 2-1 win over North Korea.

South Korea faced Uzbekistan later Saturday in another quarterfinal at Sydney. On Sunday, Japan heads into the final quarterfinal against the Philippines, also in Sydney, with three wins from three games and a tournament-leading 17 goals without conceding.

The semifinals are set for Tuesday and Wednesday, with the final to be played next Saturday in Sydney.

World Cup spots: All four semifinalists at the Women's Asian Cup qualify automatically for next year's World Cup in Brazil. The North Koreans will have another shot at qualifying for the World Cup in a playoff next Thursday in Australia — the fifth — and sixth-place teams in this continental tournament will also secure spots in Brazil. The end of the group stage earlier in the week was overshadowed by Iran's departure from the tournament and the granting of asylum to members of the delegation.

BCCI to felicitate T20 WC winning Indian team



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The Suryakumar Yadav-led Indian team, which scripted history by winning the T20 World Cup, will be felicitated by the BCCI during its annual 'Naman Awards' ceremony here on Sunday.

The highlight of the BCCI Naman Awards 2026 will be the felicitation of all five Indian teams that have captured ICC titles recently, a historic first, the Indian cricket board announced on Saturday. The Gautam Gambhir-coached side defeated New Zealand by 96 runs in the final in Ahmedabad on March 8 to become the first team to win the T20 World Cup three times, the first to successfully defend the title and the first to achieve the feat on home soil. The ceremony will also honour the other Indian sides who lifted ICC trophies in the recent past, including the senior women's team that won the ODI World Cup 2025, the men's team that clinched the ICC Champions Trophy

2025, the Under-19 Cricket World Cup 2026 and the women's U-19 T20 World Cup team of 2025.

Meanwhile, the BCCI also officially confirmed several individual honours that were already known earlier this week. India's Test and ODI captain Shubman Gill will receive the Polly Umrigar Award for Best International Cricketer (Men) for the 2024-25 season, while Smriti Mandhana will be honoured as the Best International Cricketer (Women) for the fifth time in her career.

Former stalwarts Roger Binny and Rahul Dravid will be conferred the Col. C.K. Nayudu Lifetime Achievement Award, the board's highest honour, while former India captain Mithali Raj will receive the BCCI Lifetime Achievement Award for Women.

Binny, a member of India's 1983 Cricket World Cup-winning team and the tournament's highest wicket-taker, later served the game as coach, selector and BCCI president from 2022 to 2025.

Bhambri-Goransson's dream run at Indian Wells Masters ends in semifinals

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Indian Wells (USA)

Indian doubles ace Yuki Bhambri and his Swedish partner Andre Goransson's impressive campaign came to an end after losing in the semifinals of the Indian Wells Masters in California.

The unseeded pair went down 5-7, 7-6(7), 5-10 to France's Arthur Rinderknech and Monaco's Valentin Vacherot in a closely-fought contest that was decided by a tie-breaker.

Bhambri and Goransson started strongly but were edged out in the opening set. The Indo-Swedish duo



fought back to force a decider after clinching a tight second-set in the tie-breaker.

However, Rinderknech and Vacherot held their nerve in the deciding tie-breaker to seal the victory.

Despite the defeat, the tournament marked a significant milestone for the 33-year-old Indian as it was his maiden semifinal appearance at an ATP Masters 1000 event. Earlier in the tournament, Bhambri and Goransson had produced a strong performance to reach the last-four, defeating the Austrian-Italian pair of Alexander Erler and Andrea Vavassori 6-3, 7-6(7).

Their run also ended a two-year wait for an Indian presence in the semifinals of a Masters 1000 tournament since Rohan Bopanna won the title at the Miami Open in 2024.

This could be Dhoni's last IPL season, says Irfan Pathan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Former India all-rounder Irfan Pathan believes the upcoming edition of the Indian Premier League could be the "last time" fans see MS Dhoni turning out for Chennai Super Kings.

As the 2026 IPL approaches, once again the talks surrounding Dhoni's retirement has again gathered pace.

The speculation intensified after CSK traded Sanju Samson from Rajasthan Royals, a move that many felt could allow the veteran to further minimise his on-field involvement this season while continuing to mentor the side. "CSK is incomplete without MS Dhoni. This

season might be the last time we see him in the yellow jersey and it's tough to imagine CSK and the IPL without him," Irfan said on JioHotstar's 'Game Plan'.

"As soon as the IPL comes around, we start seeing Mahendra Singh Dhoni again, which means he is fully prepared for it, and he is looking very fit as well," he added.

The 44-year-old has already joined the CSK camp in Chennai earlier this month and has been training alongside the squad led by captain Ruturaj Gaikwad.

Pathan said Dhoni's role could increasingly revolve around guiding the group and helping the next generation of leaders develop within the side.



"This season, Dhoni will play an important role in bringing everyone together. I'm not sure how many games he will play. But his presence in the dressing room will help a lot.

"Sanju will benefit because he will be part of the leadership group as well. Ruturaj

Gaikwad is the leader. But as a group, two or three guys are being groomed for the future. That is where MS Dhoni comes in. I hope he makes a difference.

"Questions about his fitness, batting position, and whether he will play all games will still come up.

The CSK team management will take it step by step. They will definitely look to give him a perfect farewell by lifting their sixth IPL trophy."

Dhoni has played 278 IPL matches across two franchises — CSK and Rising Pune Supergiant during the 2016 and 2017 seasons when CSK were suspended — scoring 5,439 runs in the tournament. Last season he was seen mostly in brief cameo roles during the death overs as he made 196 runs from 13 innings. CSK CEO Kasi Viswanathan, however, has said the veteran will be available for the full season and is expected to play "all matches" in the 2026 campaign. Pathan also felt that time has come for the

younger players to gradually shoulder more responsibility within the franchise.

"We have seen him take responsibility for a number of years now, but I think this is the time for the baton to pass on to the likes of Ayush Mhatre, Dewald Brevis, Shivam Dube and Ruturaj Gaikwad, who is a young captain as well.

"CSK's ideology has changed. It will be key for the youngsters to learn from MS Dhoni's experience, and for him to take the players ahead alongside him. It is a very exciting team on paper. In terms of six-hitting ability and intent, I am really looking forward to seeing the fearlessness from this young CSK side."

Dua aur Dastarkhwan

Shadows stretch across the courtyard as a lone dua marks the night, with strangers sharing dates before the market's *raunaq* brings everyone together, says SAKSHI PRIYA

Can a lone dua bridge that hollow gap between a day of hunger and the loud joy of the evening spread? These red sandstone slabs at the Jama Masjid have seen this shift every single year since 1656. There is an old saying that fasting is a mirror for the soul, a thought that carries heavy weight during these long Ramzaan days. When the sun starts to drop, thousands of people pack into the vast courtyard while men gather around the central water pool for *wazu*. They splash cold water over their tired skin, a simple act that cleans both body and mind before the evening prayer starts.

Looking around the courtyard reveals how this festival deeply connects the community, ensuring nobody ever sits alone. When the loud siren finally wails and the evening *azaan* starts, they end the long fast together with a single date and a sip of water to complete the sacred ritual of *iftaari*. This exact moment acts as the bridge between *Dua* aur

Dastarkhwan and captures the real heart of the night. Once the prayers finish, the deep quiet goes away as thousands of people walk out to join the massive rush. Everyone pushes straight into the bright, tight lanes of Matia Mahal to start the big feast.

The food roots in these narrow lanes go deep, stretching back to the Mughal age. Royal cooks once ran massive kitchens on this very pavement to feed people after a day of fasting. That old habit never died. Legendary names like Karim's and Al Jawahar still guard those original imperial recipes. They cook the same meals the old kings used to eat. It offers iconic street food dishes like charred *kebabs*, golden *sahi tudka*, and slow-cooked *nihari* that become especially popular during Ramzaan. The feast begins right on the pavement where cooks flip heavy iron skewers of those *kebabs* over open flames, creating a loud sizzle of fat dropping onto hot coals. Moving down the lane brings you to the heavy cooking where one vendor uses a huge spoon to mix a giant metal pot of *Chicken Biryani* before handing out steaming portions to everyone waiting. Right next to his stall, thick *haleem* bubbles in a large iron pot while cooks use heavy wooden poles to mash the meat and lentils together until it gets sticky and rich. Diners tear off big pieces of fluffy, fire-baked *khamiri roti* to scoop up every single bite of that heavy *haleem*. And not to miss, *mutton korma* inside giant copper vats. Diners pack onto small wooden benches for



A MEAL SHARED WITH STRANGERS

Strangers reach into their bags to share whatever they brought. One person hands out slices of fruits while the man sitting right beside him passes around a few dates. People naturally offer a piece of their own meal to whoever is sitting right there beside them on the floor. Seeing thousands of people share food like this shows exactly how the holy month brings everyone closer together.



WHEN THE SUN STARTS TO DROP, THOUSANDS OF PEOPLE PACK INTO THE VAST COURTYARD WHILE MEN GATHER AROUND THE CENTRAL WATER POOL FOR *WAZU*

STACKS OF HISTORY

The food roots in these narrow lanes go deep, stretching back to the Mughal age. Royal cooks once ran massive kitchens on this very pavement to feed people after a day of fasting. Tradition says the Prophet always broke his fast with a date, making this a sacred habit for millions today. It is the perfect food because the natural sugars hit the bloodstream to wake up a tired body. You can find the soft *Kimia* dates from Iran or the dark *Ajwa* that people bring back from their travels.



KHAJOOR



SEVIYAN



NIHARI



SEEKH KEBAB

Weaving a story of lost love

TEAM VIVA

As the warmth of summer approaches, heritage textile label Istri Vastra has introduced a refreshing new chapter with the launch of its latest clothing range alongside the opening of its second store in Lajpat Nagar. The collection celebrates breathable fabrics, versatile silhouettes and the enduring appeal of Indian textiles.

Spread across an inviting retail space, the new store brings together the label's signature womenswear collections along with the debut of its menswear extension, iVastra. The summer range highlights clothing designed for both everyday comfort and festive elegance. For women, the collection features a vibrant assortment of unstitched suits, dupattas, sarees, fabrics and lehengas, drawing inspiration from timeless Indian crafts such as Bandhani, Kantha and Warli-inspired motifs.

The newly introduced menswear line, iVastra, expands the brand's aesthetic into a thoughtfully curated range for men. The collection includes shirts, kurtas, shurtas, bandhgala jackets and custom-made sherwanis, offering styles that move seamlessly from family gatherings to celebratory occasions. Designed with comfort and understated elegance in mind, the garments reflect a philosophy of heritage clothing that feels natural and accessible in modern life.

Leading the menswear ini-



tative is Vaani Arora, who represents the next generation of the family behind the brand. Having grown up surrounded by textiles and design conversations, she brings a fresh perspective while remaining deeply rooted in the cultural values that have shaped the label for more than three decades. Her vision for iVastracentres on creating menswear that honours Indian tradition while adapting to the rhythms of contemporary lifestyles.

The launch evening transformed the store into more than just a fashion showcase. Guests were welcomed into an immersive cultural experience that blended clothing with storytelling traditions. A special baithak-style session titled "Qisse aur Sur" recreated the evocative atmosphere of clas-

sical dastangoi, where stories, music and memory intertwined. Led by singer and senior journalist Abhilasha Ojha, the performance brought alive narratives that echoed the spirit of heritage, much like the textiles themselves.



The Eid Wardrobe



SAKSHI PRIYA

Spring 2026 brings a rather beautiful shift in our wardrobes. The vivid colours of Holi have finally washed away, leaving behind a lively energy that smoothly flows right into Eid preparations. Shoppers lean heavily into comfortable luxury this season. Look closely at the latest designer racks, and you will notice movement remains the ultimate goal. Flowing shararas stand out as an absolute festive staple. Dramatic capes and draped silk skirts also completely dominate the scene right now. Women want breathable, fluid fabrics paired with intricate handwork to stay comfortable during long family gatherings.

Finding the right balance makes or breaks these bold silhouettes. The beauty world has largely moved away from heavy contouring for 2026. A fresh, dewy skin base lets

MAY THIS EID FASHION BECOME THE PERSON. LET THE COLOUR DEFINE THE MOOD AND LET THE PHOTOS TELL THE STORY



your eye makeup do the heavy lifting instead. Think deeply smudged, kohl-rimmed waterlines mixed with a soft wash of metallic copper or rose gold eyeshadow to instantly brighten the face. Heritage jewellery makes a major comeback when choosing accessories. A pair of heavy chaandbalis, a traditional mathapatti, or a delicate hair passa brings a regal touch to any outfit without feeling overly cluttered. Adding a classic stack of colourful glass bangles finishes the look beautifully. If you are hunting for garments capturing this exact seasonal shift, the new *Aber* collection by 11 Tareng fits the brief perfectly.

Founders Jayshree Kojiam and Reena Ahanthem named this line after the Manipuri word for gular. They blend traditional Meitei motifs with bold Punjabi influences absorbed while growing up in Delhi.



The duo actively champions quiet elegance. Their pieces are kept free from heavy embroidery so the radiant sheen of Khurkul silk takes centre stage. Jaysree and Reena suggest modern women can beautifully style these fluid capes, suits, and dhoti pants by layering them over unexpected separates and adding heirloom headgear.

Can a single thread carry the weight of a generation? This unhurried, slow-fashion ethos aligns with the spiritual focus of the approaching holy month.

To the founders, Ramadan embodies a season of rigour, a sentiment found in the slow, deliberate work of the handloom. Fast, throw-away trends have no home here. The focus remains on crafting culturally rich heirlooms built to be passed down and treasured over years. Holiday dressing remains a private journey. Selecting a vivid silhouette that reflects a personal identity, paired with heavy heritage jewellery, ensures an individual commands the room.

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The Pioneer AGENDA

The future belongs to our youth. Younger people must take over. They must seek and cherish the most basic condition for peace.
- Nelson Mandela



Nepal Wraps Up Old Guard, Rapper at the Helm

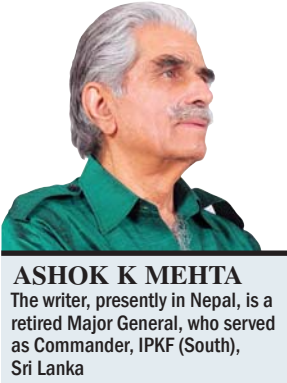
Nepal's latest election marks a decisive break with the past. Frustrated with years of political stagnation, voters have rejected traditional parties and handed an opportunity to a new generation of leaders led by Balendra Shah

Nepal infuses fresh blood in the system

Nepal's latest elections on March 5, following last year's Gen Z *Andolan*, were revolutionary, resulting in seismic political change - a greenhorn party sweeping aside the traditional old guard. "OMG" prefaced the announcement of the Rashtriya Swatantra Party (RSP) lead by TV anchors during vote counting the next day. Nepal has seen several upheavals, the latest led by the RSP, which is determined to transform the country by eliminating corruption and catalysing development.

The turning point came when former rapper and 35-year-old former Mayor of Kathmandu, Balen Shah, a Madhesi by birth and Pahari by culture, joined the charismatic former TV host and president of the RSP, Rabi Lamichhane. There is a third, lesser-known "transformer": Gen Z's Sudan Gurung, who brought Shah and Lamichhane together and later joined the RSP. This combination was complemented by the party's magnetic election symbol, ghanthi (bell), which rang in an unprecedented craze and wave (lehar) that swept away the old parties - Nepali Congress (NC), Communist Party of Nepal-United Marxist Leninist (CPN-UML) and the Communist Party of Nepal (Maoist Centre). During two other recent regime changes in the neighbourhood, the old order was only partially altered in Bangladesh by barring an entrenched political party from elections. In Sri Lanka, however, a former revolutionary group responsible for two insurrections was voted to power with a two-thirds majority, wiping out the old guard.

The RSP is two seats shy of a two-thirds



ASHOK K MEHTA
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majority, with 182 seats (63 women) in the 275-member Parliament. Conspicuously, it does not have a single member in the 59-seat Upper House and has no presence in any of the seven provinces. The NC is reduced to 38 seats, the UML - the biggest loser - to just 25, and the former Maoists to 17 seats. This represents an abysmal decline, reducing them to less than half their strength in the previous House. The Left parties together had 110 seats earlier, compared with just 42 now. Notably, 42 defectors contesting on RSP tickets defeated seasoned politicians, while 40 per cent of lawmakers are below the age of 35. The RSP's extraordinary majority has wiped out Madhesi parties and reduced Royalists to five seats from 14. People voted for the Ghanthi, not individual candidates, demolishing the political standing of two former Prime Ministers - KP Sharma Oli and Madhav Nepal. A third former PM, Prachanda, the consummate survivor, chose the safest constituency, Rukum, from where he had launched the civil war. Shah's local police guard even trounced technocrat Kulman Ghising, popularly known as the "Bulb Man" and credited with ending Kathmandu's power cuts - such as the fervour among voters. After three decades of coalition governments, a single-party government will now be formed.

Here lies the tricky part. The RSP has had only one leader hold cabinet rank - Rabi Lamichhane as Home Minister, though he has been shadowed by cases of cooperative fraud, organised crime and money laundering and is currently out

on bail. Lamichhane remains the party chair, while Shah is expected to lead the parliamentary party and become Prime Minister. A seven-point gentleman's agreement between Lamichhane and Shah is said to outline power-sharing arrangements. This recalls a similar pact between Oli and Prachanda in 2017, which Oli never honoured, eventually leading to the collapse of the Nepal Communist Party.

In his first campaign speech at Janakpur, Shah declared: "A son of Madhes will be the next Prime Minister of Nepal." Following last year's Gen Z protests and Oli's resignation, the search for an interim Prime Minister was reportedly being led by Sudan Gurung, when Shah's name also surfaced. At the time, however, Shah remarked: "The Army should appoint one." Besides the RSP's lack of experience in government, Parliament may suffer from a weak opposition and the absence of seasoned leaders. Weak institutions, a bureaucracy in need of reform and limited resources could hinder the ambitious pledges outlined in the party's election manifesto and the "100 Goals" document.

Fitch Ratings noted this week that the RSP's clear parliamentary majority reduces political uncertainty, potentially improving predictability in the implementation of economic reforms and governance - something largely absent during previous fragile coalition governments. However, the RSP's targets are highly ambitious: 7 per cent GDP growth from the current forecast of 4.5 per cent for 2026, doubling the economy to USD 100 billion, generating 30,000 MW of electricity, raising exports to USD 30 billion from the current USD 1.5 billion, and creating 500,000 jobs over the next decade. These goals appear unrealistic.

CONTINUED ON >> P11

Pent-up anger overthrows the ruling elite

Nepal's 2026 elections have produced a phenomenal democratic mandate. The Rashtriya Swatantra Party (RSP), barely four years old, has secured a near two-thirds majority in Parliament, falling short by just two seats. Across the world, the result is being hailed as one of the most remarkable democratic shifts in Nepal's contemporary politics. Many international observers and media outlets have described the result as a "Gen Z-led political wave." I disagree. The story of this mandate runs deeper than generational change. What we are witnessing is the culmination of decades of accumulated "rees" (anger) and "bethiti" (misgovernance) in Nepali society.

The peaceful conclusion of elections becomes even more significant when seen against the turbulence of the previous year. The events of March 26, 2025 and September 8-9, 2025 will go down as dark days in Nepal's contemporary history. These days have exposed the fragility of democratic institutions, law and order, civic ethics in the media, and even the silence of observers. Violence, destruction of public and private property, fatalities, and excessive use of power revealed how fragile Nepal's governance structure had become.

Yet the electorate responded not with despair, but with a decisive democratic verdict. The seeds of alternative politics and younger demographic representation sown in the 2022 General Elections bore fruit. Historic mayoral wins in Kathmandu, Dhangadhi, and



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political system is a powerful metaphor to reflect on where Nepal stands today and the way forward.

Fragile stability amid chaos

Two decades of political transition following the end of the armed conflict were marked by unstable coalitions and the exchange of power among a handful of leaders. Accountability remained elusive. Across the country, polarisation deepened. Civil society and media engagement increasingly reflected political preferences rather than independent scrutiny of national challenges. Even the Nepali diaspora was not immune; party loyalties often shaped social cohesion abroad.

The development narrative became increasingly concentrated around Kathmandu and Pokhara, while cities such as Birgunj and Janakpur remained peripheral to the national conversation. Hopeful Balendra Shah will integrate these cities into Nepal's mainstream development discourse.

Opportunities for quality education, employment, or entrepreneurship remained limited. At the same time, streets like Putalisadak and Dillibazar were filled with billboards of consultancies offering pathways abroad for study or work. The message to a generation was unmistakable: opportunity lay outside the country. Over time, anger accumulated silently. Social media became the principal outlet for frustration. Tolerance levels declined. Polarisation intensified. Those who did not vent their anger publicly often chose silence as their coping mechanism. But silence has consequences. Over the years, it has bred indifference to the pain of others.

The unrest witnessed in March and September 2025 was therefore not sudden. It was the eruption of pressures that had long been building beneath the surface. The immediate challenge before RSP is therefore not merely governance and policy implementation but restoring trust. Dialogue with political parties, civil society, and non-state actors will be essential. Consensus may not emerge on every issue, but rebuilding confidence in institutions is critical to move beyond the present sense of helplessness.

Nepal today lives with what might be described as fragile stability amid chaos. The system is functioning-but only barely. The bridge hangs; it does not stand. It suggests a political structure sustained by tension rather than trust. One wrong movement, and the entire structure could sway or snap.

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'Nepal's 2026 electoral moment represents a transition rather than a destination. A bridge exists to connect two sides, but crossing it can feel precarious'

CHRONOLOGY OF NEPAL'S POLITICS (2008-2026)

May 28, 2008 - Monarchy Abolished
Nepal formally ends its 239 year old monarchy and became a Federal Democratic Republic.

July 23, 2008 - First President Elected
Dr. Ram Baran Yadav became the first president of Nepal under the new republic system.

2015 - New Constitution Adopted
Nepal adopted a new constitution establishing a secular, federal democratic republic and strengthened rights framework.

March 9, 2023 - Presidential Election
Ram Chandra Poudel elected as president, continuing the republic political framework established after monarchy.

September 8-13, 2025 - Gen Z Protests & Political Storming
Widespread youth led protests erupted across Nepal leading to the resignation of then Prime Minister K. P. Sharma Oli.

March 2026 - General Election & New Mandate
Parliamentary elections held. Balen Shah is now poised to become Nepal's next prime minister



KP Sharma Oli, Former Prime Minister of Nepal (front); Gagan Kumar Thapa, The president of the Nepali Congress (back).

“NEVER THINK THAT WAR, NO MATTER
HOW NECESSARY, NOR HOW
JUSTIFIED, IS NOT A CRIME”
— ERNEST HEMINGWAY

Unshaken: The week Dubai proved its resilience

When our family moved to Dubai about 50 years ago, beyond the tiny cluster of Bur Dubai lay nothing but a rolling ocean of sand. In family gatherings, my father-in-law has often regaled us with nostalgic stories of how neighbourhoods in Dubai's city centre today were perceived as the middle of the desert at that time. The population of no more than 20,000 then felt like a close-knit community.

Dubai, unlike some of the other emirates, had no oil. So the city and its economy had to be built from the ground up by the sheer ambition, vision, and hard work of its residents. There were signs then of the first stirrings of a global metropolis, but none that could have revealed Dubai's mighty future.

Dubai, where oil still accounts for less than one per cent of its GDP, is home to 200 nationalities — of which about five per cent are local Emiratis. Dubai's distinct skyline proudly shines, towering over the surrounding raw, untamed beauty of sand dunes and the rugged Hajar Mountains. It is a city that has offered the world a new model for city culture by being safe, progressive, and incredibly diverse. Contrary to popular perception, personal freedom in Dubai far exceeds that offered in the eight more westward-located countries such as France and Switzerland where I have lived. Today, it is this magnificent city that is under attack.

On the 12th day of the US-Israel versus Iran war, the city woke up to an alert of another missile attack. The UAE military has so far intercepted 278 ballistic missiles, 15 cruise missiles and 1,540 UAVs from over our homes. We hear the bangs in the day and during the night, often accompanied by the rattling of our walls.

There is shock. On the sunny Saturday morning of 28 February, no one could have, in their wildest dreams, expected to be hit by 167 missiles and more than 200 drones.

There are unanswered questions. What does a peaceful country such as the UAE have to do with the war between the US-Israel and Iran? If it is the US bases located in the UAE that are indeed being targeted, then why are missiles and drones being shot at airports, ports, hotels, and residential buildings in Dubai?



MINIYA CHATTERJI
CEO, Sustain Labs Paris

There is uncertainty. Where will the debris of the next intercepted missile fall?

There are changes. We have shelters within our homes to walk into when we are informed by the government of an approaching missile attack. We have altered our place of sleep, moving to basements

or ground floors where possible, and away from windows. Our lives have adapted to the indoors to stay safe from falling debris from intercepted missiles and drones.

There is bafflement. As we face the Iranian attacks, the reaction by those who have never lived in the UAE has included unbridled snark, a catharsis of vicious envy, horrific AI-generated fake news, and an inexplicable glee at our perceived suffering.

Yet there is no fear. Dubai's first line of resilience is its uncompromising approach to security. The UAE has invested heavily in world-class, multi-layered air defence systems that have demonstrated a high rate of success in intercepting the Iranian attacks. This technical capabil-

ity is matched by a composed and calm leadership that has clearly prioritised de-escalation and maintained a neutral stance.

For the city's millions of residents and expatriates, this translates into a daily life that remains largely uninterrupted. Malls, schools, and offices continue to operate normally, reflecting a deep-seated public trust in the state's protective measures.

The UAE has chosen to prioritise its people by opting for regional de-escalation and peace. It has demonstrated humility and an attitude of deep responsibility and service to its people. The UAE President, Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, has said:

“As for the residents who live amongst us, they are our guests and our extended family. They have truly honoured us with their stance. We hope they will forgive us if we have fallen short in any way. I promise them that we will fulfil our duty, because it is our obligation to protect our people and our country.”

The UAE Ministry of Foreign Affairs has also stated that “the UAE officially confirms it remains in a strictly defensive state against this direct aggression. The UAE strongly emphasises that it actively avoids being drawn into broader, unnecessary, destructive regional conflicts.” Dubai's residents

are led by the composure of the government, confidence in the country's military strength to defend the skies, and the knowledge that the leadership will not give them away in exchange for power, ego, and war.

Pragmatism and calm remarkably rule over knee-jerk reactions, even amongst Dubai's business leaders. In an interview that took place well after the advent of the Iranian attacks on Dubai, prominent UAE businessman Mohammad Alabbar praised the Iranian people and the beauty of their country. He said that once things settle down, there is no reason why he would not invest in Iran. “We cannot change the map,” he said thoughtfully.

The fate of the US-Israel versus Iran war is unknown, as the conflict engulfs more countries every day. Yet only those who have the strength not only to defend themselves but also to choose not to retaliate will be the real winners as they emerge unscathed. There is a belief among residents that, through the leadership's stance of non-violence and compassion, the UAE will be excluded from the ongoing regional conflict.

The city of Dubai has risen like a phoenix from the sand, overcom-

DUBAI UNDER ATTACK

Dubai is facing an unprecedented wave of drone and missile attacks from Iran.

Impact on Key Infrastructure: The attacks have targeted the very pillars of Dubai's economy, disrupting its aviation, finance, and logistics.

Dubai International Airport (DXB): The world's busiest airport for international travel has been struck multiple times. Incidents include a drone strike on March 7 that caused widespread disruption.

Economic Disruption: Operations at the Jebel Ali Port — the world's ninth busiest — were interrupted by fires caused by falling debris from intercepted projectiles.

Tourism and Luxury Landmarks: High-profile sites have not been spared. Debris from interceptions caused fires at the Fairmont The Palm and the Burj Al Arab hotels.

Civilian Safety: As of March 10, the UAE reported six deaths and 131 injuries primarily due to shrapnel and falling debris.

ing unfathomable challenges along the way. Much of that is attributed to the lack of drama, knee-jerk reactions, reckless tweets, anger, and emotional outbursts — which are now far too common in global political theatrics.

Its progressive policies do not always make world headlines. Legislation has dramatically changed in recent years to attract new residents and businesses, passing supportive labour laws and liberal visa rules. Toppling global business centres such as London, the ease and opportunities of doing business in Dubai are unparalleled. Its art district in an industrialised zone and its inimitable youth football culture are all remarkable, even if they do not always make the cut for some of the Western highbrow. Dubai's landscape too celebrates human ingenuity and triumph over adversity. It is not difficult for Dubai to deal with discomfort. These Iranian attacks too shall pass.

The past 12 days have shown the world that the true beauty of Dubai lies in its resilience. It would serve as proof that Dubai, in all circumstances, continues to be a safe haven with unscathed skies, infrastructure, and spirit.

The writer is CEO, Sustain Labs Paris and a Global Leadership Fellow alumna of the World Economic Forum



THE FATE OF THE US-ISRAEL VERSUS IRAN WAR IS UNKNOWN, AS THE CONFLICT ENGULFS MORE COUNTRIES EVERY DAY. YET ONLY THOSE WHO HAVE THE STRENGTH NOT ONLY TO DEFEND THEMSELVES BUT ALSO TO CHOOSE NOT TO RETALIATE WILL BE THE REAL WINNERS



FROM AGENDA COVER

Nepal infuses fresh...

Fitch Ratings adds: “Nepal's weak government effectiveness and regulatory practices will constrain implementation.” It also does not account for potential headwinds from the Gulf conflict, where 1.8 million Nepali workers remit nearly USD 10 billion annually. Already, reports suggest that half-filled gas cylinders are being supplied.

Lamichhane has pledged a “balanced and independent” foreign policy with a focus on development diplomacy, while earlier he had spoken of non-alignment.

Shishir Khanal, the party's head of international department, noted there would be no shift in foreign policy emphasizing importance of centuries old cultural, social and economic ties with India and maintaining One China policy while securing gains from Beijing's dynamic economic growth. The spotlight as before will be on immediate neighbours and the third power, US. New Nepal will not only have to balance India and China but also US and China. Both are competing for space and influence with Washington's US 774mn MCC programme pitted against BRI projects that have been designed but not funded even after a decade. US has also sought to include Nepal in its Indo Pacific strategy by getting it to join its State Partnership Programme which envisages military-to-military cooperation between US National Guard and Nepal Army. So far, Nepal has shown little inclination or interest in SPP. Traditionally Nepal has been careful not to upset Beijing over the Tibet issue. The unarticulated tilt to India is provided by strategic geography and open borders. PM Modi has congratulated the people of Nepal on a successful election that will provide stable government and spoken to Lamichhane and Shah. Delhi should not judge Shah by his random and offensive statements he had made as Mayor of Kathmandu.

In one sense it is advantage India. The decline

of Left parties majority in Parliament from 60 per cent to 25 per cent should lift the veil over Agniveer and reopen Nepal Domiciled Gorkha recruitment to Indian Army which is a necessary strategic bonding in bilateral relations. India's traditional political partner was the Nepali Congress and after a time, even Prachanda Maoists. But for now, it is the bell that will ring out in Delhi.

Pent-up anger leads to the structural change

Nepal's governance challenges can be viewed through three lenses: geostrategic, domestic, and institutional.

Geostrategically, Nepal has long navigated a delicate balance among major powers. Located between India and China, the country historically followed the metaphor articulated by King Prithvi Narayan Shah - Nepal as a “yam between two boulders.”

This framework allowed Nepal to maintain balanced relations with partners including India, China, the United States, Japan, Australia, and the European Union.

Recent discourse, however, increasingly frames Nepal's diplomacy as balancing simultaneously among China, India, and the United States. Such framing overlooks historical realities. Nepal's deepest economic and social linkages remain intertwined with its immediate neighbourhood. Even Chinese strategic thinking dating back to Mao Zedong acknowledged that India-Nepal relations would naturally remain deeper because of civilizational and societal ties.

Maintaining this equilibrium remains central to Nepal's strategic autonomy.

The height magnifies fear. Every step matters. In politics, this mirrors leadership choices where a misstep doesn't just bruise, it can trigger collapse, unrest, or legitimacy loss.

Political self-goals and the rise of RSP
The rise of RSP was also facilitated by the failures of established political parties.

The Nepali Congress, historically central to Nepal's democratic movement, struggled with internal fissures and leadership crises. By the end of 2025, generational tensions weakened the party significantly.

This decline is striking given the party's historic role. Leaders such as Matrika Prasad Koirala once maintained deep political connections across the region, even briefly presiding over the Bihar unit of the Indian National Congress during India's freedom struggle.

Such political capital gradually eroded. Many loyal supporters simply chose not to vote.

Meanwhile, the Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist-Leninist) faced declining popularity under K. P. Sharma Oli. His familiar nationalist rhetoric, often framed through anti-India sentiment, no longer resonated strongly with voters. Oli's revival of engagement with China's Belt and Road Initiative through a new cooperation framework generated symbolic headlines but little political traction. His political friction with emerging leaders such as Rabi Lamichhane and Balendra Shah further reinforced the perception of disconnect between established leadership and public sentiment.

The handling of the 2025 unrests, in March and September including the controversial social media ban, ultimately triggered wider youth mobilization and intensified public frustration.

Institutions: the real test

Winning elections is easier than governing.

The new leadership inherits institutions weakened by years of political interference and fragmented donor-driven reforms. Corruption allegations frequently dominate headlines but rarely lead to decisive outcomes.

The controversy surrounding Pokhara

International Airport illustrates this problem. Reports of irregularities have circulated publicly, yet investigations remain inconclusive while the project continues to place financial pressure on the national exchequer.

Similarly, low capital expenditure has remained a recurring concern raised by international financial institutions. Administrative costs have increased even as development outcomes lag behind expectations.

Nepal's federal structure adds another layer of complexity. Only a limited number of countries operate federal systems, most of them large and institutionally mature democracies. For a smaller state like Nepal, evaluating whether a two-tier or three-tier system ensures efficiency and accountability may become an important policy debate. Suspension bridges rely on cables more than pillars. Politically, this can imply a state held up by institutions, personalities, foreign backing, or coercive power, rather than democratic foundations.

Transition, not destination

Nepal's 2026 electoral moment represents a transition rather than a destination.

A bridge exists to connect two sides, but crossing it can feel precarious. Those designing the bridge may feel secure, yet those walking across it feel exposed.

This metaphor reflects the gap between political elites and ordinary citizens.

Whether Nepal's recent mandate becomes a milestone of democratic consolidation or merely another phase in its long political transition, will depend on how effectively the new leadership restores trust, strengthens institutions, and reconnects governance with the aspirations of its people.

(The writer is a Nepal Observer and a financial, geopolitical and security analyst)

GENERATIONAL HOPE

Balendra “Balen” Shah is a former rapper turned politician and structural engineer who has rapidly risen to national prominence in Nepal. Originally known for his socially conscious rap music — with tracks like “Balidan” (meaning “sacrifice”) critiquing corruption and inequality — Shah became a symbol of youth frustration. His music resonated with younger voters and urban audiences long disillusioned with traditional leadership.

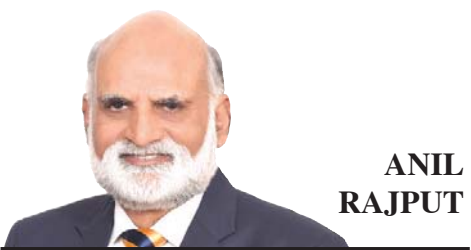
Shah entered formal politics in 2022, winning the mayoral election in Kathmandu as an independent candidate on an anti corruption and reform agenda, defeating established party contenders. His tenure as mayor was marked by efforts to improve transparency, urban infrastructure and governance, though it also drew some criticism for confrontational tactics.

In early 2026, Shah joined the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) as its prime ministerial candidate and led the party to a landslide victory in the general election, beating veteran leaders and securing a commanding majority.

Educated in Nepal and holding a master's degree in structural engineering from India, Shah blends technical training with grassroots activism. At around 35 years old, he embodies a generational shift in Nepali politics, championing anti corruption, job creation and broader reforms as he prepares to lead the country's government.



Eid-ul-Fitr: Celebration, Gratitude, and its Cuisine



ANIL
RAJPUT

The sighting of the crescent moon that marks the end of the fasting month of Ramadan brings with it the joyful arrival of Eid al-Fitr, a festival of devotion, gratitude, and celebration. After a month of restraint and prayers, from dawn to dusk, the day of Eid unfolds as an occasion of spiritual fulfilment. Families and friends gather for prayers of gratitude to exchange greetings and gifts. New, smart clothes are adorned to suit the occasion. The atmosphere is festive. Yet, the day carries a deeper significance as it commemorates the completion of a period of spiritual discipline intended to cultivate humility, compassion, and generosity.

The origins of Eid-ul-Fitr lie in the earliest traditions of Islam, established during the lifetime of Prophet Muhammad in the seventh century. Ramadan, the sacred month of fasting, was instituted as a time for reflection, charity, and discipline. Each day of fasting reminded believers of patience and empathy for those less fortunate. Zakat al-Fitr, thus, became a significant part of this occasion. An act of charity, Zakat is one of the central obligations in Islam and requires every financially viable person to contribute to the welfare of the disadvantaged. During Eid, this act purifies the fast besides supporting the needy to celebrate the festival with dignity. From its earliest origins, the festival has been inseparable from the values of generosity and shared sustenance. Food, therefore, becomes not only a symbol of celebration but a reminder that abundance carries with it a responsibility to share and nourish others.

In India, Eid-ul-Fitr acquired a particularly rich culinary dimension as Islamic traditions encountered the diverse food cultures of the subcontinent. The Mughal courts refined elaborate feasts, regional kitchens adapted local ingredients, and centuries of coexistence shaped dishes that now define Eid celebrations. While fasting during Ramadan cultivates restraint, Eid encourages generosity and hospitality. The act of serving food becomes the principal expression of goodwill.

Sweet



dishes traditionally appear first, and sets the celebratory mood. The meal follows through savoury dishes, breads, and fragrant rice preparations, each representing not only culinary skill but also the warmth of communal celebration. Among the most iconic preparations associated with Eid-ul-Fitr is sheer khurma, a delicately fragrant dessert whose very name evokes festivity. Vermicelli is gently roasted in ghee until golden and simmered in milk enriched with dates, sugar, and a generous assortment of nuts such as almonds, pistachios, and cashews. The mixture is scented with cardamom and sometimes saffron, creating a dish that is both comforting and festive. The dates hold deep symbolic significance as it is traditionally used to break the fast, and lends natural sweetness and texture. Served warm in the morning after prayers, sheer khurma is shared with family members and visiting guests alike. Its preparation often begins the night before, allowing the milk to absorb the fragrance of spices and nuts so that the dessert is ready to be served by the morning.

Alongside sheer khurma, seviyan occupies an equally cherished place on the Eid table. Fine strands of vermicelli are roasted in ghee and cooked in milk sweetened with sugar until it thickens into a rich pudding. Some households prepare a lighter version known as dry seviyan, where roasted vermicelli with sugar, cardamom, nuts, and raisins are served without the addition of milk, producing an equally fragrant sweet. In parts of northern India, sheer khurma and seviyan are both prepared, offering two variations delivering entirely different textures and experiences.

Another dessert frequently prepared is phirni, a refined rice pudding traditionally served in shallow earthen bowls. Ground rice is slowly simmered in milk until the grains dissolve into a smooth consistency, after which sugar, saffron, and cardamom are added. The mixture is poured into small clay dishes once it thickens and imparts a subtle earthy fragrance. Garnished with pistachios and almonds, phirni is often chilled before serving. The simplicity of its ingredients contrasts with the patience required in its preparation, as constant stirring ensures that the rice cooks evenly and the milk thickens without scorching.

Equally beloved is shahi tukda, a dessert that reflects the culinary refinement of the Mughal kitchens. Slices of bread are fried gently in ghee until crisp and then soaked in fragrant sugar syrup before being layered with thickened milk known as rabri. The final dish is garnished with pistachios and strands of saffron. Though seemingly simple, its indulgent richness and layered textures make it a centrepiece of many Eid feasts. The balance between crisp



bread, syrup, and creamy milk transforms a humble ingredient into a dessert that evokes royal kitchens. In the Deccan, particularly in Hyderabad, double ka meetha appears as another beloved festive sweet. Prepared from fried bread simmered in saffron scented milk and enriched with nuts and dried fruits, the dessert reflects the refinement of Hyderabad culinary traditions while carrying a sweetness that perfectly complements the celebratory spirit of Eid. Halwa preparations also make frequent appearances during Eid. Suji halwa, prepared from semolina roasted in ghee and cooked with sugar syrup, cardamom, and nuts, offers a warm and aromatic sweetness that complements the morning meal. In some regions, carrot halwa prepared from grated carrots simmered slowly with milk, sugar, and khoya adds another dimension to the festive spread. The vibrant colour and mellow sweetness of carrots create a dessert that feels both comforting and celebratory, particularly when garnished with roasted almonds and pistachios.

Balancing these sweets are an array of savoury dishes that sustain the long hours of social visits and gatherings that characterize the day. Biryani assume pride of place, particularly in households that host extended family and guests. Long grained basmati rice is layered with marinated meat cooked with onions, yogurt, ginger, garlic, and aromatic spices such as cinnamon, cloves, and cardamom. The rice absorbs the fragrance of saffron and ghee as it steams in a sealed pot, producing a dish whose aroma alone signals festivity. Served with cooling raita or tangy salad, biryani embodies both celebration and hospitality.

Among the gravies that accompany these rice dishes, mutton korma holds particular distinction. Tender pieces of mutton are simmered slowly in a sauce enriched with yogurt, browned onions, and ground nuts, creating a preparation that is both aromatic and deeply satisfying. The gentle sweetness of caramelized onions balances the warmth of spices such as cardamom, cinnamon, and cloves, while the slow cooking allows the meat to absorb the richness of the gravy. Served with naan, sheermal, or roomali roti, mutton korma remains one of the most anticipated dishes on many Eid tables.

A variety of kebabs are another savoury highlight of Eid gatherings. Seekh kebabs, prepared from finely minced meat blended with spices, herbs, and onions, are shaped around skewers and grilled until smoky and succulent.

Shami kebabs, by contrast, combine minced meat with soaked lentils and spices before being shaped into patties and shallow fried. Their delicate texture and gentle spice make them particularly suitable as starters served alongside chutneys and sliced onions. Galouti kebabs, famed in the culinary heritage of Awadh, are even more delicate, the meat ground so finely that the patties dissolve almost instantly upon tasting. In the Deccan, particularly in Hyderabad, pathar ka gosht adds another distinctive preparation to the festive spread. Marinated slices of mutton are cooked on a heated granite stone, allowing the meat to sear quickly while retaining its tenderness and smoky flavour, creating a preparation that reflects the culinary traditions of the region.

For many families, rich gravies and slow cooked dishes form the centrepiece of the main meal. Nihari, a slow cooked stew whose origins trace back to Mughal Delhi, is prepared by simmering cuts of meat overnight with spices until the broth becomes deeply flavourful and the meat tender enough to fall apart. Served with freshly baked bread and garnished with ginger, green chillies, and lemon, nihari exemplifies the patience and depth characteristic of traditional Eid cooking. Haleem, though often associated with Ramadan evenings, also finds a place on Eid tables in many households. Wheat, lentils, and meat are cooked together for hours until the mixture transforms into a thick porridge enriched with spices and ghee, then garnished with fried onions, coriander, mint, and lemon making for an irresistible dish that is both nourishing and deeply flavourful.

Breads play an important role in completing the Eid meal. Sheermal, a lightly sweet saffron flavoured bread baked in tandoors, is particularly popular in northern India. Its soft texture and subtle sweetness complement rich gravies such as mutton korma. Roomali roti, thin and delicate, is folded into layers and served warm alongside kebabs and stews. Naan, brushed with butter or ghee, remains a universal accompaniment that allows diners to enjoy the gravies and meats prepared for the occasion.

Another festive preparation that frequently appears on the Eid table is zarda rice, a fragrant sweet rice dish whose bright colour and rich aroma symbolize celebration. Long grains of basmati rice are cooked with sugar, saffron, and

ghee until each grain glistens with sweetness. Nuts, raisins, and candied fruits are folded into the rice, creating a dish that balances fragrance and texture. Served alongside savoury dishes, zarda rice represents the harmonious blending of sweet and savoury that characterizes many festive meals of the subcontinent.

No Eid celebration would feel complete without the beverages that accompany these meals and offer refreshment throughout the day. Rooh Afza sharbat, with its deep rose colour and fragrance of herbs and fruits, is perhaps the most recognizable drink associated with Eid in the subcontinent. Mixed with chilled water or milk and often garnished with basil seeds, it provides cooling relief after a rich meal. Falooda, a layered drink combining rose syrup, vermicelli, basil seeds, and milk, transforms refreshment into dessert like indulgence. Badam milk prepared with ground almonds, saffron, and cardamom offers another traditional drink that nourishes and refreshes. In many homes, simple sharbat made from lemon, sugar, and mint provides a light counterpoint to heavier foods, while lassi made from yogurt delivers both refreshment and digestive comfort.

Across the many regions of India, these dishes appear in different combinations yet convey the same message of generosity and celebration. From the delicate sweetness of sheer khurma, seviyan, phirni, and double ka meetha to the savoury richness of biryanis, kebabs, pathar ka gosht, mutton korma, and nihari, the cuisine of Eid-ul-Fitr reflects centuries of culinary exchange and shared cultural memory. Each dish carries within it a living culture, tradition and unique craftsmanship, creating a cuisine designed to relish and share. Ultimately, I believe, the cuisine of Eid-ul-Fitr is far more than a festive indulgence. It represents the culmination of a month devoted to discipline and reflection. When families gather around the table, they celebrate not only the end of fasting but also the values that fasting cultivates. Gratitude for nourishment, generosity toward others, and the strengthening of bonds within the community find expression through the act of sharing food.

As evening approaches and visits between friends and relatives continue, what remains is the sense that Eid has fulfilled its purpose. It is my sincere belief that in preserving these culinary traditions, we ensure that Eid-ul-Fitr continues to nourish both body and spirit. It therefore becomes our collective responsibility to ensure that the heritage that comes with the festival endures not only in prayer and charity but also in kitchens where dishes are prepared with care, served with generosity, and shared in the spirit of fellowship that defines the day.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

A Michelin-starred culinary journey

TEAM AGENDA

An intimate culinary showcase in New Delhi recently brought together the precision of Japanese technique and the finesse of modern European cooking in an elegant eight-course tasting experience. The event featured Austrian Michelin-starred chef Philipp Dyczek, whose cuisine is known for its disciplined approach to ingredients, seasonality and refined craftsmanship.

Chef Dyczek, the founder of Restaurant ARTIS- which earned its first Michelin star in 2025- presented a menu inspired by the Japanese omakase philosophy, where each dish arrives as a carefully considered progression of flavours and textures. The result was a dining experience that balanced restraint with creativity, highlighting the chef's ability to weave together culinary traditions without losing their individual character. The journey began with a delicate Bluefin Tuna O-Toro Tartlet, where the buttery richness of the tuna was complemented by creamy white bean, basil and fresh wasabi. The crisp tart shell added texture while allowing the natural flavour of the fish to shine.

This was followed by a King Crab Beignet, a golden and airy preparation filled with sweet crab. Accents of pickled dill and parsley cut through the richness, creating a dish that was both indulgent and balanced. One of the most vibrant courses of the evening was the Hamachi Ceviche, where tender hamachi met a bright tomato-pineapple vinaigrette. Daikon, tarragon, lime caviar and wasabi contributed freshness and acidity, making the dish lively and refreshing.

The menu then moved into deeper, more nuanced territory with Austrian Chicken Chawanmushi- a silky savoury custard infused with chicken and root vegetables. Subtle hints of banana, cocoa and miso added unexpected complexity while maintaining the delicate character typical of the Japanese classic.

Seafood again took centre stage with Skrei and



Red Snapper poached in brown butter and served with a dashi beurre blanc. The pairing of French sauce technique with Japanese umami created a harmonious interplay of flavours, enhanced by smoked pea, kombu oil and shiso. A heartier course followed in the form of Suckling Pig, served with apple, pumpkin seeds and mustard alongside a creative kale sushi element. The aromatic warmth of Kampot pepper tied the dish together.

The final savoury course featured Duck with Water Spinach and Green Asparagus, gently perfumed with lemongrass and ginger, before the evening concluded with a light Topfen Soufflé accompanied by Riesling sabayon and vanilla ice cream. A thoughtfully designed vegetarian tasting menu mirrored the same creativity, ensuring that the experience remained inclusive while maintaining the chef's signature elegance and balance. Together, the courses formed a memorable culinary narrative that celebrated craftsmanship, subtlety and global influences.

AAHAR: Stirring the pot of global flavours

TEAM AGENDA

Every year, the global food and hospitality industry looks to New Delhi to identify the next big shift in the market. Now in its 40th year, AAHAR remains the essential hub for these international professionals. The Ministry of Food Processing Industries and the India Trade Promotion Organisation jointly oversee the massive exhibition at Bharat Mandapam, which serves as a critical link. The event places local farmers directly in front of global buyers. What happens when the quiet work of a local harvest transforms into a global currency for a hungry world? These gatherings propel financial strength and cultivate a sincere sharing of culinary heritage across every frontier.

The 18th Culinary Art India injected a sharp, competitive bite into the trade floor. Organised by the Indian Culinary Forum, this national-scale gathering united hundreds of professionals and students. All tested their skill against exacting international benchmarks. Over a multi-day marathon, 159 chefs competed in high-pressure categories, performing tasks ranging from intricate pastry sculptures to live sandwich assembly and technical rice preparations.



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

A panel of WACS-certified international judges scrutinised every plate. Led by Chef Rick Stephen, this group evaluated entries based on technical precision, flavour, and hygiene. Chef Davinder Kumar, President of the Indian Culinary Forum, noted that the high turnout reflects a growing hunger for structured competition. Such events push chefs outside the limits of their standard kitchen shifts.

The sprawling exhibition halls showcased an array of brands dictating current culinary trends. Heritage names sat alongside modern startups. Within the fair directory, Mohan Ghee stood out, presenting its premium A2 Bilona Desi Ghee.

The fairgrounds transformed into a sprawling map of global flavours, where the surgical precision of sushi platters sat alongside a fantastical 'land of cakes'. In this section, bakers forced flour and sugar into towering, architectural shapes. These showcases mirrored a distinct industry swing toward health-focused, lactose-free dairy. In separate sessions, veteran chefs fronted masterclasses, offering a rare look at the hard reality of modern kitchens. This mix of professional training and live theatre, covering everything from chocolate carving to sugar work, marks AAHAR 2026 as a standout date for global hospitality.

THE INTERNATIONAL FOOD
FAIR BRINGS CUTTING EDGE
KITCHEN TRENDS AND
FIERCE CULINARY
COMPETITION TOGETHER



Why Talent Is Not Enough in the Corporate World

A good leader is satyadarshi — truthful; samdarshi — equanimous; priyadarshi — pleasant personality; pardarshi - transparent; and doordarshi — farsighted. He or she has a mission, a vision, a spirit of sacrifice, compassion, and commitment

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

Talent is important, but talent alone is not enough. How this talent is executed is equally valuable. A person may be extremely capable, but if the mind is stressed, restless, or distracted, that talent cannot be expressed or executed effectively. Even the most talented person may struggle to perform well. On the other hand, when the mind is calm and focused, even someone with moderate ability can achieve extraordinary results.

Studies have found that people from previous generations had stronger ACC (Anterior Cingulate Cortex), a specific functional region in the frontal part of the brain involved in emotion, decision-making, and impulse control, which helps someone become resilient. Today, we see that attention span and patience have considerably shrunk. Unless you take care of their mental wellness, no matter how talented a person you hire, you end up seeing that they are not doing what they are supposed to do, or at least as well as they are supposed to do. This is something organisations across the world are beginning to realise.

Twenty years ago, when I talked about wellness, people were not necessarily concerned about it. Today, it has become a part of the language that corporates speak. Today, firms are keen to know how to de-stress and bring the enthusiasm from within their people.

There is a big difference between motivation and inspiration. Motivation is short-lived - it comes from outside. You give an increment or a promotion, people work well for some time, then the motivation dies out. But inspiration comes from within and endures for a long time. When people are inspired from within, they continue to excel. That is what we call IT — not Information Technology but Inner Transformation. Wherever there is sincerity and talent, it does get recognized. All that is needed is patience. One should not be feverish about success. When there is feverishness, one ends up making wrong decisions. It is not difficult to climb up the corporate ladder by hook or by crook, but then you fall down the ladder faster than you climbed. If your goal is clear, and you have the patience to move in that direction, nature supports you.

A major aspect of good leadership is letting go of control. Are you in control of your body functions? Are you in control of your thoughts? No. When you realise that the idea that you are in control is an illusion, you will be able to relax. A relaxed mind is a sharp mind and becomes a far more effective decision-maker.

The one who manages this universe does not make it obvious that He is in control. Similarly, leading from behind the scenes is the best. There is a saying in Sanskrit: Paroksha Priyahi Vai Devaha — the Gods like to do things indirectly. They give people the joy of feeling that they are doing it, but in reality, it is the Divine energy that does it subtly. The same principle applies to



“A SIMPLE PRACTICE CAN HELP. WHENEVER YOU HAVE AN IMPORTANT DECISION TO MAKE, PAUSE FOR FIFTEEN SECONDS AND TAKE A COUPLE OF DEEP BREATHS. IN THAT SMALL GAP, CLARITY ARISES”
— GURUDEV

building high-performing teams. Just imagine if everyone in the organisation walks around feeling insecure, depressed, unhappy, and lonely — what sort of company would you be building? Can you make any progress? The secret of management begins with developing trust among leaders. When you walk around with your mind saying, 'I don't trust you,' the same thing reflects in the world outside. Those managers who deal with an equanimous mind handle challenges far better. Those who are not impulsive — their perception is better, their expression is better, and their observation is better.

A sense of belongingness with everyone makes one a better leader than someone who thinks, 'I am different, and I know better.' In any business setup — whether it is a factory, your office, or business — there is a clerk working day and night for you. If you take a few moments to personally wish them, interact with them, deal with them, that human relationship, that sense of being one among them, is a vital quality of leadership. A leader is also one who has a good attention span, has the patience to listen to the

other person, and can put himself in the shoes of the other person to see the point of view from the other side. This amounts to having a multi-dimensional understanding of any situation.

Just talent is not enough, but one must lead by example, too. Being totally open and honest is its foundation. If you make a mistake, you simply admit it. If you try to cover one mistake, it leads to another mistake, then another. That only makes you weak. A true leader will neither complain nor explain, and is open to learning all the time. A leader has to strike a balance between diplomacy and straightforwardness. It is like tuning a guitar — if the strings are stretched too tight, you cannot play it, and if the strings are too loose, you cannot create music either. How we give feedback to someone is also important. Often, we point out someone's mistake because their mistake hurts us. When you go to correct someone's mistake with this attitude, it never brings transformation. What we need to say is: 'What you are doing will eventually hurt you, so change.' That brings the transformation. A good leader creates leaders, not fol-

lowers. He takes good care of those whom he is leading. He delegates responsibility. A short-sighted leader creates a mob; a leader with wisdom creates a movement.

We are all looking for ways to make our workforce more productive, positive, inspired, and enthusiastic. For this, we need to give them tools to energize their bodies and minds. There are largely four sources of energy that we know of: food, sleep, breath, and a calm and meditative state of mind. Among these, breath and meditation often go unnoticed, yet they help in bringing transformation within. When you begin to understand the rhythms and patterns of the breath, you gain the ability to release negative emotions, whether it is anger, frustration, tiredness, stress, or even depression. When the mind is restless or impulsive, you tend to react quickly and push people away. But when the mind is calm, you are able to listen to both sides of a story and make wiser decisions.

A simple practice can help. Whenever you have an important decision to make, pause for fifteen seconds and take a couple of deep breaths. In that small gap, clarity arises. Decisions made from that space rarely go wrong.

At times, when you are in leadership positions for a long time, the ability to be a follower diminishes. Even if you happen to follow, you find fault with another's leadership, which results in



A MAJOR ASPECT OF GOOD LEADERSHIP IS LETTING GO OF CONTROL. ARE YOU IN CONTROL OF YOUR BODY FUNCTIONS? ARE YOU IN CONTROL OF YOUR THOUGHTS? NO. WHEN YOU REALISE THAT THE IDEA THAT YOU ARE IN CONTROL IS AN ILLUSION, YOU WILL BE ABLE TO RELAX. A RELAXED MIND IS A SHARP MIND AND BECOMES A FAR MORE EFFECTIVE DECISION-MAKER.

resistance. The best leaders know how to be a leader and a follower at any time. When you are a leader, do not stop being a student — else you will lose something very precious. A leader never stops learning. He considers himself to be a perpetual student and learns from everybody, even from a child. Celebration, relaxation, sense of belongingness, and constantly updating oneself with different skillsets — these are avenues we should never stop exploring.

A good leader is satyadarshi — truthful; samdarshi — equanimous; priyadarshi — pleasant personality; pardarshi — transparent; and doordarshi — farsighted. He or she has a mission, a vision, a spirit of sacrifice, compassion, and commitment. All this may sound utopian, but in reality, if you look keenly into the lives of the most successful leaders, you will find all these qualities naturally manifest at some time or other. You don't have to do much to inculcate these leadership skills — just their awareness is good enough to make a good leader.

A quiet map to the inner life

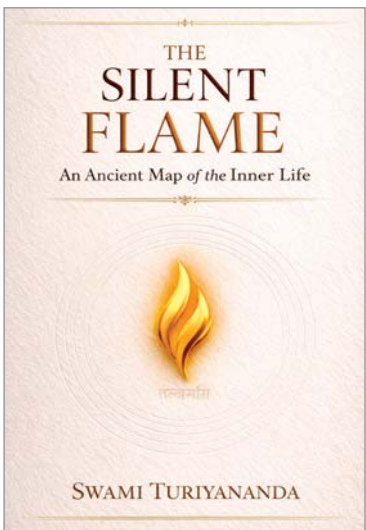
TEAM AGENDA

In *The Silent Flame - An Ancient Map of the Inner Life*, Swami Turiyananda offers a contemplative yet intellectually rigorous exploration of the human inner landscape. Drawing from the ancient wisdom of the Taïttiriya Upanishad, the book introduces readers to the concept of the Panchakosha — the five layers of human existence and presents it not as religious doctrine but as a practical framework for understanding the modern condition of inner fragmentation. The book begins with a strikingly simple but profound moment: a question that arises unexpectedly in the author's life while flying over the Arabian Sea. Despite a successful career in global finance, the author finds himself confronting a quiet but persistent inquiry: What is all of this leading toward? This moment becomes the gateway to a deeper exploration of life beyond external achievement. What makes the book particularly compelling is its refusal to frame the modern individual as “broken.” Instead, Turiyananda argues that contemporary life disperses attention across endless responsibilities and stimuli, leaving the inner dimensions of the self underdeveloped. His central insight—that human beings are not broken but dispersed-forms the philosophical core of the book.

The framework he introduces, the *Panchakosha*, describes the human being as a layered architecture: the physical body (Annamaya), the energetic field of breath and vitality (Pranamaya), the mental and emotional landscape (Manomaya), the faculty of discernment (Vijnanamaya), and the innermost ground of quiet awareness (Anandamaya).

These layers, the author explains, are not metaphysical abstractions but observable dimensions of everyday experience. When aligned, they produce clarity and steadiness; when fragmented, they generate the subtle unease many high-functioning individuals quietly carry.

Structurally, the book unfolds in three movements. The first, “The Audit,” examines the pressures and rhythms of modern life that pull attention outward and crowd out stillness.



Author: Swami Turiyananda
Word count: 55,000

Rather than condemning ambition or achievement, Turiyananda simply asks readers to look honestly at what has been neglected in the pursuit of success.

The second section, “The Blueprint,” introduces the Panchakosha in accessible language, grounding each layer in lived experience. Here the author's background in analytical disciplines becomes evident; he presents ancient philosophy with clarity and precision rather than mysticism.

The final section, “Integration,” explores how alignment among these layers can be restored. Importantly, the author does not advocate elaborate spiritual techniques. Instead, he emphasises recognition — a form of knowledge the Upanishadic tradition calls jnana. This recognition involves rediscovering a quiet inner continuity that has always existed beneath the surface turbulence of life.

What distinguishes *The Silent Flame* from many contemporary spiritual books is its tone. It avoids sentimental reassurance and dramatic promises of transformation. Instead, it offers something rarer: a carefully drawn map. Readers familiar with works by thinkers such as Eckhart Tolle or Viktor Frankl will recognise a similar search for meaning, though



Turiyananda's contribution lies in grounding that search within the structured philosophical framework of Vedanta.

The prose itself reflects the spirit of the book-measured, contemplative, and quietly persuasive. Rather than instructing the reader what to believe, the author invites careful observation of one's own experience. In an age of constant motion and external achievement, *The Silent Flame* serves as a reminder that clarity does not arise from adding more activity but from understanding the architecture of one's own being.

ABOUT AUTHOR

Swami Turiyananda represents an unusual bridge between two worlds. An All-India ICSE Board topper and Singapore Government Scholar, he studied engineering at Nanyang Technological University before completing an MBA in Finance at the University of London. He then worked in investment banking with institutions such as Barclays Capital and CLSA in London and Singapore.

A turning point came when a persistent existential question led him to leave finance and pursue years of disciplined study within the Vedantic tradition in the Himalayas. Today, from his ashram in Badrinath, he teaches contemplative philosophy to students from around the world, translating ancient frameworks into language accessible to modern professionals.



Behind Closed Doors: A murder mystery rooted in fear, memory and human frailty

TEAM AGENDA

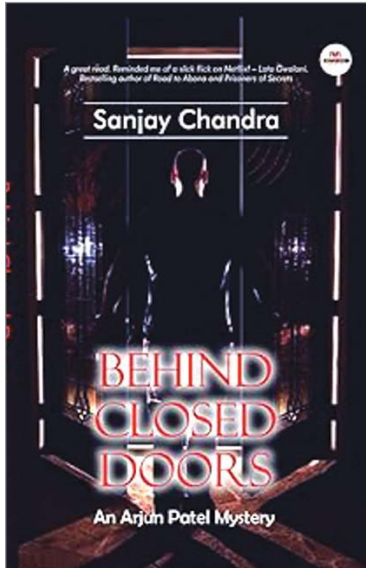
In *Behind Closed Doors*, Sanjay Chandra places a classic murder mystery within a setting that feels immediately recognisable to contemporary readers: a gated residential complex in Gurgaon in the uneasy days preceding the Covid lockdown. What begins as an apparently sealed-room death gradually opens into a wider narrative about family secrets, buried emotions and the uneasy social hierarchies that shape modern urban life.

The story begins with the sudden death of Anubhav, found lifeless in his apartment while his wife Charu sleeps beside him. The doors and windows appear locked from within, and the initial assumption is that illness may have caused the death. But the post-mortem points elsewhere, and the mystery begins to deepen. Enter Arjun Patel, a retired Mumbai Police Commissioner with a reputation for solving complex cases. His presence gives the narrative its investigative momentum, but the novel's deeper interest lies not merely in identifying the killer, but in exploring the emotional fault lines hidden beneath apparently orderly lives.

One of the book's strengths lies in its setting. The high-rise condominium becomes more than a backdrop; it functions as a social microcosm where class, ambition, reputation and quiet resentment coexist. Residents, security guards, delivery workers and office-bearers of the Residents' Welfare Association all inhabit the same physical space while moving through sharply different social realities.

Author captures the rhythms of this environment with familiarity, allowing the setting itself to contribute to the tension, as proximity does not necessarily translate into trust, and privacy often coexists with constant observation.

Importantly, the environment Chandra depicts is one that readers will instantly recognise. The gated condominium, with its security protocols, resident committees, domes-



Title: Behind Closed Doors
Author: Sanjay Chandra
MRP: ₹ 499
Publisher: Aabs Publishing House

tic staff, delivery personnel and carefully maintained appearances, has become a defining feature of the modern Indian urban landscape. By situating the mystery within such a familiar setting, the novel acquires an added layer of immediacy: the crime does not occur in some distant or exotic environment but within the everyday spaces that many urban readers inhabit.

The investigation gradually draws attention to several possible suspects, each with a plausible motive or unresolved history with the victim. A disgruntled former guard, an ethically compromised RWA secretary, figures from Charu's past and members of the extended family all emerge as potential players in the unfolding drama.

Suspicion shifts across this network as Patel methodically examines the relationships and circumstances surrounding the death. Interviews, recollections and fragments of personal history slowly assemble into a pattern that reveals how ordinary

lives may conceal extraordinary tensions.

Arjun Patel himself is one of the novel's steadier elements. Rather than presenting him as an eccentric detective, Chandra shapes him as a seasoned investigator marked by personal loss and professional discipline.

His backstory adds emotional gravity to the narrative and gives his pursuit of truth a moral urgency. Patel's investigative style relies less on theatrical deduction and more on patient observation and careful reading of human behaviour. This measured approach allows the narrative to unfold gradually, building suspense through accumulation rather than sudden revelation.

The novel also attempts to move beyond the mechanics of the murder. Through the lives of its characters, it touches upon themes of loneliness, suppressed desire, ambition and the quiet fractures within domestic relationships. In this sense, the title *Behind Closed Doors* resonates on two levels: the literal mystery of the locked room and the hidden emotional worlds people carry within their lives. The narrative suggests that significant conflicts often remain concealed beneath surfaces of normalcy and routine.

Chandra's prose is clear and direct, prioritising narrative movement over stylistic flourish. This approach suits the genre well, allowing the reader to follow the progression of clues and revelations without distraction. The final resolution arrives in the classic detective tradition, with the investigator assembling the pieces of the puzzle and revealing the logic behind the crime.

What ultimately gives the novel its resonance is the suggestion that violence rarely emerges in isolation. Beneath the surface of ordinary lives lie unresolved tensions, private disappointments and quiet obsessions. *Behind Closed Doors* reminds readers that the most unsettling mysteries often unfold not in distant or unfamiliar places, but within spaces that feel disarmingly familiar.